

CAPTAIN GIDEON LOOTS

THE SURGEON

book one



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A Note to the Reader

This is the complete first draft of *The Surgeon*, a Cape crime novel: five parts, twenty-four chapters, from the kindnesses to the masterpiece.

— Arjuna Badger Press, workshop shelf

PART I — THE KINDNESSES

*“Everyone sees what you appear to be; few experience what you really are.” — Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince**

One — The Kindnesses

I have never hurt anyone.

I want that understood before anything else, because everything else will be used against me. I subtract hurt. I find the small cruelties the world has left on people — the scar, the blemish, the asymmetry that catches their eye every morning in the mirror before they have even had coffee, before they have had a chance to defend themselves — and I take those cruelties away. Quietly. Without fuss. Without so much as a thank-you, which is the part no one believes: that a man might do a generous thing and deliberately forgo the gratitude. But gratitude is a currency, and currency leaves a trail, and besides — Machiavelli is very clear on this — it is better to be loved by everyone and known by no one.

Tonight I am subtracting a scar from the face of a woman named Margaux.

She doesn't know this yet. At the moment she knows only that the man beside her at the wine bar on Victoria Road has ordered the 2019 Chenin she'd have chosen herself if she'd had the courage of her convictions, that he listens the way a warm bath listens, and that he has not once looked at her chest. She is thirty-one. She does something with brand strategy that she describes with an apology folded into it, the way they all apologise here, on this coastline, where everyone is somebody's content. She has a scar through her left eyebrow, a pale comma about eleven millimetres long, and when she thinks no one is watching she touches it. She touched it four times before I sat down and twice since, and each time her face performs a small privacy, a going-away, and I know — the way you know a dog is about to bite, the way you know a heifer will kick before her leg

so much as twitches, because knowing is my training — that she has hated that scar since she was nine years old.

Bicycle, I'd guess. Handlebar or gravel. Some summer afternoon that ended in iodine and a father saying *it gives you character*, which is the sort of thing fathers say when they mean *I can't fix it*.

I can fix it.

"You're staring," she says, and smiles to license the staring.

"I am," I say. "I'm sorry. You have a very mathematical face."

This is a terrible line, objectively. I use it because it is terrible — because a handsome man saying a smooth thing is a pattern her defences know, and a handsome man saying an awkward, nerdy, sincere thing is a pattern her defences wave through with a smile. Charm, real charm, is not polish. It is the strategic distribution of flaws. I keep a small wardrobe of them: the shirt collar one degree wrong, the laugh a half-beat late at my own expense, the terrible line delivered with visible regret for the terribleness. *Everyone sees what you appear to be*, says my oldest friend, the Florentine, from the annotated copy that lives beside my bed the way other men keep scripture. *Few experience what you really are*.

"Mathematical," she repeats, deciding to be delighted. "That's a new one."

"There's a ratio," I tell her. "The golden one. Phi. One point six one eight and then it never stops — the decimals go on forever, no pattern, no mercy. The Greeks thought it was the signature of beauty. The distance between your pupils, against the width of your mouth. Nose to chin, against chin to hairline. When a face approaches the ratio we call it beautiful and we don't know why we said it." I turn my glass by its stem. "Yours is close. Closer than anyone else's in this bar, and yes, I checked, and yes, I understand that checking is strange."

She laughs — the real one, not the ambassadorial one she was using earlier — and for a moment the whole manufactured coastline of her recedes and there is just a woman with a bright, unguarded face and a comma of old damage through one eyebrow, and I feel the thing I have decided to call tenderness because the available alternatives are worse.

“Close,” she says. “But no cigar?”

“Nothing living lands on it exactly,” I say. “That’s the point of it. It’s an irrational number. Perfection is irrational.”

I say it lightly, the way you hand someone a stone and don’t mention it’s a meteorite.

She touches the scar. Fifth time. “Story of my life,” she says, and turns her glass, and her mouth does the going-away thing again, and under the table where she cannot see it my hand rests on my knee with the stillness I learned holding a scalpel above breathing tissue for the first time, the stillness that came to me instantly and completely, like recognising a room you grew up in — and I think: *there. That, exactly that, is what I do not accept about the world as furnished.* Not the scar. The going-away. The small tax the mirror charges her every single morning, compounding since she was nine. Eleven millimetres of handlebar gravel levying twenty-two years of interest.

No. I don’t accept it.

The evening folds itself away neatly after that, the way my evenings do. There is a second glass she will not remember and a taxi she will not remember and there is, for six hours, the room I do not describe to anyone, because it is mine the way the inside of my own chest is mine — and I will tell you only what matters from it, which is this:

She sleeps the way children sleep, absolutely, with her hands open.

The lamp makes its cone of surgical daylight in the dark and the instruments lie in their rows with the calm of things that have exactly one purpose. I have measured her face — properly now, calipers, not bar-light flirtation — and entered the numbers in the ledger, in the column hand I have used since second year, and her ratios are what I told her they were: close. Extraordinarily close. She runs one comma flat of the ineffable, and the comma is not even hers; it was installed by gravel, by accident, by the world’s general commitment to vandalism, and the world had no *right*.

Work at this scale is not cutting. It is diplomacy at the border of the visible: persuading eleven millimetres of old, proud, disorganised tissue to stand down and let the skin remember what it meant to do all along. It takes me forty minutes. I will not tell you how. That

knowledge cost me six years and it is not for sale, and anyway you would only hear the technique and miss the substance, which is that for forty minutes the entire operating theatre of my attention is hers, more completely than anyone has attended to her in her adult life — more than her mother, more than the men, certainly more than the surgeon who would eventually have done this for forty thousand rand and a follow-up consult if she'd ever forgiven herself enough to book it. People say *care* when they mean *worry*. I mean the older word. Curation. The keeping of a thing.

When it is done, the comma is a hyphen, and in ten days the hyphen will be a rumour, and in a month there will be nothing over her left eye but the uninterrupted argument of her actual face.

She will never know. That is not a flaw in the gift. That *is* the gift. Every other kindness she has ever received arrived with an invoice stapled to it — the boyfriend's generosity that wanted managing, the brand's empowerment that wanted engagement, her father's *character* that wanted her to stop crying about it. Mine is the only one with no sender. She will find it the way you find spring: gradually, then all at once, in a mirror in good light, touching her eyebrow with the same two fingers and finding the tax office closed, the debt cancelled, the ledger — hers, I mean; mine is immaculate — wiped.

I drive her home along the coast with the windows cracked so the cold Atlantic air can do its honest work on her blood, and I walk her up as the concerned acquaintance every night guard on this strip has seen a hundred times, and I put her on her bed dressed and covered and turned on her side, with a glass of water on the nightstand and two paracetamol beside it like a signature I refuse to sign. Her flat is exactly what I expected: rented seaview, ring light on a tripod, a bookshelf arranged by colour. On the fridge, a magnet says LIVE LAUGH LOVE, unironically. I stand in her kitchen for one minute in the dark, listening to her breathe through the open bedroom door, and I feel the feeling I have never found in any of the literature, not in the diagnostic manuals — where I have read my own weather forecast often enough: the glibness, the grandiosity, the shallow affect, all of it laid out like a menu I ordered from before I was born — and not in Machiavelli either, who comes closest. The feeling of being the only one awake. The night nurse of the whole sleeping coast.

Then I let myself out, and lock her door behind me with her own

spare key, and post the key back through the gap beneath, and by the time the sky over the Twelve Apostles goes the colour of diluted iodine I am over Kloof Nek and out of the city, on the N1 and then the R310, over Helshoogte with the vineyards unrolling below me in their long combed rows, and this is the part of the night I would keep if I could only keep one part: the mountains black as theatre curtains, the first light coming up gold as a lamp over a table, and the rows — have you ever noticed this? — the rows curling away across the hills in arcs and spirals that no one designed to be beautiful. Contour ploughing. Erosion mathematics. Farmers solving for water and accidentally writing phi across forty hectares. Nature does not chase the ratio. Nature *is* the ratio, effortlessly, asleep — and only we, of all the animals, wake up every morning and vandalise ourselves, and call the vandalism fashion, and pay for it.

Somebody has to be the correction.

In Stellenbosch the oaks are dripping with the night's mist and the town smells of bread and eucalyptus and money. I park behind my flat on the Braak side, shower, and walk to campus with my satchel over my shoulder like any other final-year, because I am any other final-year: Christiaan Vermeulen, fourth in the cohort — third would attract attention, fifth would attract concern; fourth is invisible — of the faculty everyone is still so proud of, the province's shiny new veterinary school, so new the paint still squeaks, so new the systems still trust the people inside them. At eight I will be in the large-animal theatre gowning up to assist Professor Krige, who calls me *seun* and means it, with a bovine caesarean, and my hands will do their quiet impeccable work, and at some point Krige will say what he always says — *jy's gebore hiervoor, Vermeulen* — born for this — and I will smile the modest smile, flaw number three from the wardrobe, and think about the letter.

I keep it in the flat, in the drawer with my ledger, flat as a pressed flower. Faculty of Medicine and Health Sciences. *We regret that we are unable to offer you a place.* Eleven years old now, the paper gone the yellow of old teeth. They regretted. They were unable. One mark — the margin was one mark, in a language paper, marked by whom, moderated by whom, on which afternoon of whose distracted life — and the door to human medicine closed, and the door to animal medicine opened, and everyone agreed it was a pity and everyone

agreed I took it so well.

I took it so well.

Here is what I know that they do not: a body is a body. Skin is skin, breath is breath, the sleeping trust of the anaesthetised is the same warm weight in every species, and six years of the only surgical education this country would sell me have been — I say this without bitterness, bitterness is for people who lost — a superior residency. Harder cases. Less forgiving patients. Not one of whom ever exaggerated a symptom, thanked me, reviewed me, or lied.

And here is the other thing I know, the thing that arrived last night in her kitchen in the dark and has not left, the thing I turn over now in the scrubbed light of the theatre while the professor's radio plays and the morning's first patient breathes on the table under my steady, celebrated hands:

Subtraction is a beginning. You can spend a life erasing the world's vandalism and the face beneath will still only ever be what accident issued — close to the ratio, a comma flat, no cigar. For eleven years I have been the tax office in reverse, the cancelled debt, the closed ledger, and it has been enough, it has been *plenty* —

But nothing living lands on it exactly.

And I have started to wonder, lately, in the gold hour driving home over the pass, what it would take — how little, really, how few millimetres — to land one.

Two — The Faculty of Second Choices

The calf comes out of the flank incision at seven minutes past nine, steaming in the theatre's cold air, and Professor Krige says *daar's hy*, there he is, the way he always says it — as if the calf were an argument he has just won — and hands me the needle driver for the closing, because the closing is mine. The closing is always mine. Krige can open a cow like a man opening post, forty years of it in his wrists, but he gives me the long quiet architecture of putting her back together, layer answering layer, because — and he has said this in front of the dean, in front of the external examiner from Utrecht, in front of God and the second-years — nobody in the building closes like Vermeulen.

“Jy's gebore hiervoor,” he says now, watching my hands. Born for this.

“Gelukkig, Prof,” I say. Lucky. Modest smile, number three from the wardrobe. The heifer breathes her big anaesthetised breaths under my forearms, twelve hundred rand of suture disappearing into her in rows as even as a vineyard, and I am — I want this on the record, whatever the record eventually becomes — happy. Genuinely. This is not a mask over a hollowness, whatever the diagnostic manuals would predict of me. The work is the one place where what I appear to be and what I am are the same animal.

It's everywhere else that requires management.

The faculty is six years old. They built it on the hill east of campus where the agronomy trial plots used to be, glass and raw concrete

and a roof like a wing, and there is still — this is true, you can smell it — paint. The province fought Pretoria for a decade for the right to train its own vets, and won, and every wall of the atrium carries the photographs of that victory: ministers with scissors, the first cohort in their new green scrubs, Krige shaking hands with a man whose name is on a wine label. A faculty so new it still believes its own systems. The card reader on the pharmacy stores logs every entry, and nobody reads the log, because the log is me: I compiled the variance workbook in third year when the stores went over to the new inventory system and nobody else would volunteer, and it has been Vermeulen's workbook ever since, the way things become people's in institutions — by competence and default. Every month I reconcile what the theatre draws against what the shelf holds, and every month the numbers agree, because I am scrupulous, and because I am the one they agree with.

I want to be precise about this, since precision is the whole of my defence: I have never taken anything the workbook missed. The workbook misses nothing. What I take, the workbook absorbs — a rounding philosophy, a wastage assumption, a broken-vial allowance, each one individually defensible, each one signed off by the faculty officer whose signature is a stamp I keep in perfect legitimate custody of my role. If you audited us — and they did, last March, two men from the accreditation body with matching laptop bags — you would find what they found: exemplary. The word in the report was exemplary.

Anri Fourie thinks the wastage assumption is too generous.

She tells me this on the Thursday after the caesarean, in the stores, where we do the month-end count together because the SOP requires two signatures and Anri and I are the two people in the cohort who show up for unglamorous work. She counts left-handed, which still looks wrong to me after six years, her pen hooked over the top of the clipboard like a crochet needle, and she counts everything twice — not because she doubts herself but because the first count, she told me once, is what you expect to see, and the second count is what's there. She initials in green. She is from a sheep farm outside Sutherland where the cold makes the stars hard and the people harder, she wears the same three fleeces in rotation, she has never once laughed at any of my terrible lines, and she is the only person

in the building I consider a colleague.

“Two point one per cent,” she says. “Prof Malan’s paper on comparable facilities says point-eight is defensible. We’re allowing two point one.”

“Large-animal theatre skews it,” I say, truthfully — everything I will say in this conversation is true; that is what makes it a good conversation. “Bovine volumes. Half our draws are measured for six hundred kilos and the dead space in the lines alone —”

“I know what the dead space holds.” She makes the green initial. “I’m saying if we’re going to allow two point one, the allowance should be itemised, not assumed. Assumptions are where things live.”

Assumptions are where things live. I have thought about having that engraved.

“Bring it to the audit committee,” I say. “I’ll second it.”

She looks at me for a moment — Anri’s looks are all one look, level as a spirit bubble — and says, “You will, hey,” not quite a question, and goes back to the shelf. And here is the thing I would like the eventual record to weigh: I will. I will genuinely second it, and the allowance will be itemised, and I will redo my own arithmetic on the tighter tolerance the way a climber re-rigs for worse weather, and the workbook will go on missing nothing. People imagine that a man in my position wants lax systems. Lax systems are how you get caught — they attract auditors the way a limp attracts lions. I want the tightest system in the country, administered by me.

Afterwards we walk out through the atrium, past the wall of scissored ministers, and the cohort is organising Friday’s braai on the class group, and Anri says she’ll bring her own rooibos, deadpan, because six years of *ag come on Fourie one glass* has worn a groove that she long ago stopped bothering to fight; she doesn’t drink, has never drunk, will tell you unprompted that she has watched wine turn Sutherland men into weather. I file this the way I file everything about the people I keep — fondly, and completely, and for no reason I am yet prepared to look at straight.

My flat is two rooms behind a working gate on the Braak side, chosen

for the gate and the two exits and kept in the condition the diagnostic literature would call a red flag: nothing on the walls, one plate, one cup, the Machiavelli by the bed with its margins full of my green-less, Anri-less handwriting. In the desk drawer: the ledger, and under the ledger, the letter.

I take the letter out perhaps four times a year. This is a ritual and I know it is a ritual and I permit it, the way you permit a dog one chair. The paper has gone the yellow of old teeth. *Faculty of Medicine and Health Sciences. Dear Mr Vermeulen. We regret that we are unable to offer you a place in the MBChB programme.* Eleven years old. I know the letter the way imams know surahs. One mark, in the end — I did eventually establish this, through channels I maintained politely for years, a friendly administrator, a moderation table glimpsed at the right angle — one mark, in Afrikaans Huistaal of all things, a comprehension passage about, and I want this detail preserved because the universe does not repeat a joke this good, *a poem on inner beauty*. Marked by whom. Moderated by whom. On which afternoon of whose distracted underpaid life did a tired human being read my paragraph on what the poet really meant and dock me the mark that closed medicine and opened — this.

The province needed vets. The new faculty took the medicine-rejects with the good science marks, and everyone in that first cohort knew what we were: the faculty of second choices. They gave us a building with a roof like a wing to make up for it. And I stood in the atrium on the first day among my fellow silver medallists, all of us wearing our disappointment with different degrees of grace, and I made the only vow I have ever made: that I would take the consolation prize and strip it for parts.

Understand — the training is the same tree. Anatomy, histology, pharmacology, anaesthesiology, surgery: the same trunk, branching at species. My patients have thicker skin and honester faces. My anaesthesia is harder, not easier — try titrating sleep for an animal that cannot tell you what it weighs, what it took, what it fears. My surgery is judged by the only reviewer who cannot be charmed: the wound itself, which either heals or does not. Six years of this, plus the years before, plus the years I do not put in any account. When people say *he could have been a surgeon*, as Krige says at least monthly to visitors, with his hand on my shoulder, proud and oblivious as a lighthouse — they

are wrong only about the tense.

On Saturdays I drive to the farm.

Oom Frik's place, technically — my mother's brother, the last Vermeulen-adjacent soil left after my father finished converting four generations of Franschoek land into debt and apology — a small estate on the Pniel side, vines on the lower slopes, the werf with its white gable and its two-hundred-year-old cellar cut back into the hill. Frik is seventy-eight and lives in Hermanus now with a woman called Ounooi and his boat, and the vineyard is leased to the neighbouring estate, and the house sleeps under dust sheets, and I am the caretaker. It is the perfect arrangement, wearing its explanation on the outside the way the best arrangements do: the dutiful nephew drives out on weekends, checks the gutters, runs the taps, keeps the insurance honest. The security company knows my bakkie. The neighbours wave.

The cellar has a door of old Cape yellowwood, and then, behind the racking that any visitor would stop at, a second door, steel, from the renovation Frik half-did in the nineties when he dreamed of a private tasting room. It is the second door I stand in front of now, on this particular Saturday, with the afternoon light coming down the cellar steps behind me the colour of Chenin, and my keys in my hand, and I do not go in — there is stock to rotate and instruments whose cases need the silica changed, ordinary custodial things, but they can wait — because I am thinking about the heifer.

Specifically I am thinking about the moment on Tuesday when she was closed, the last knot buried, the line of her flank restored so cleanly that in a year a buyer will run a hand over it and feel nothing, and Krige said born for this, and I felt the happiness I have described, and then — this is the part I have been walking around all week the way you walk around a hole in a familiar floor — the happiness stopped. Not faded. Stopped, like a tap. Because she was closed, and closing is restoration, and restoration is subtraction — the removal of the wound, the cancelling of the damage, the return of the animal to what it already was. And I stood there stripping my gloves with the applause of the theatre lights on me and heard a voice I recognised as mine say, very quietly, underneath everything:

It was already only a cow.

That is the sentence. That is the whole confession, if the record wants one. Margaux's scar, Tuesday's heifer, eleven years of immaculate erasure — I have been restoring my patients to what accident issued and calling the ache afterwards virtue, the honest tiredness of the good worker, and it is not virtue. It is the ache of a man copying out other people's sentences in beautiful handwriting. Subtraction returns a thing to spec. Nothing I have ever done, not once, not to any living creature, has moved one past spec — toward the number the vine rows write across the hills without trying, the ratio nothing living lands on.

Yet.

I put my hand flat on the steel door, which is cold the way the instruments are cold, a coldness that is really a kind of patience, and I say the word out loud in the cellar, alone, where honesty is free.

"Addition."

And the door, being a door, says nothing, and the light on the steps goes from Chenin to rooibos to nothing, and I lock up the way the dutiful nephew locks up, and drive back over Helshoogte in the dark with the ledger's next blank column already ruled in my head — and if you had passed me on the pass that night, coming the other way, your headlights would have shown you a young man alone in a clean bakkie, smiling slightly, keeping perfectly to his lane. That is what I would have shown you, anyway.

That is what I show everyone.

Three — The Lost Evening

Margaux Theron woke at 11:40 on a Saturday morning with her shoes off, her dress on, and the sense — before she was awake enough to name anything — that her flat had been tidied by someone politer than her.

The curtains were drawn. She never drew the curtains; the view was the point of the rent. On the nightstand stood a glass of water, full, dead centre on a coaster she normally left in the kitchen, and beside it two white pills in a torn-off strip of blister packaging, laid parallel, like a place setting.

She lay still for a long time, doing the arithmetic of shame.

One glass at Arlecchino with Roxy, who'd left early for a date. Then the man — Chris, he'd said, just Chris, in the way of men who are confident their surname would only slow things down — who had somehow already ordered the exact Chenin she'd been circling on the list, and who'd talked about maths of all things, the golden whatever, in a way that should have been insufferable and instead had made her feel like a cathedral being appraised by someone who knew about cathedrals. She remembered laughing her real laugh. She remembered him saying *perfection is irrational* and thinking, tipsily, that she'd put it on a client deck by Wednesday. She remembered the second glass arriving.

She remembered nothing else.

Not leaving, not the stairs, not a taxi, not her door. Eleven years of Cape Town nights out and she had never once lost the walk home; she was famous among her friends for being the one who ordered the waters, who got everyone into the Uber, who remembered in the

morning what the others were grateful to forget. She lay in her drawn-curtained room with her heart going and did what women are trained to do with a hole in the night: she blamed herself into it. Wine on an empty stomach. That new pre-workout. The antihistamine she'd taken at lunch — you're not supposed to mix those, everyone said so. She built the bridge plank by plank until it more or less held her weight, and then, because the alternative was to keep standing on it, she got up.

Her phone was charging. She never remembered to charge it. On the screen, a message from a number with no name:

Made sure you got home safe. You were great company. Drink the water. — C

She read it maybe thirty times over the course of the day. It was, depending on the hour, the sweetest thing a stranger had ever done for her, and proof that nothing bad could have happened, because bad men don't leave water; and then at 2 a.m., briefly, it was the most frightening sentence she had ever received, *drink the water*, an instruction from someone who had been in her bedroom while she was not, strictly speaking, anywhere. She typed *thank you so much for getting me back!! embarrassed* ☹ and deleted it. Typed *who is this?* and deleted it. In the end she replied with a thumbs-up, the emoji of surrender, and he never messaged again, and that, she told herself, settled it: a decent guy, a bad mix of wine and antihistamines, a story she would tell at her own expense until it went smooth from handling.

She did not tell it to anyone for nine days. When she finally gave Roxy the trailer version — *I got SO wrecked, this random had to basically carry me home, I'm never drinking again* — Roxy laughed and said what everyone says, *babe you're such a lightweight*, and the story clicked into the shape stories go in the group chat, and after that it was true, more or less, because it had been witnessed.

The paracetamol she didn't take. She didn't keep paracetamol in the flat — headaches went to her neck, and her physio had opinions — and she stood in the kitchen holding the torn strip for a moment, Panado, a brand like a nursery rhyme, thinking: he had these *on him*? Then she dropped them in the drawer where the takeaway chopsticks lived, and the drawer closed over them, the way drawers do.

The month that followed was full of very small wrong things, none of them worth a sentence out loud.

Her spare key was under the mat but sideways, tucked at the wrong edge, and she stood on the landing one evening holding it and could not remember when she'd last used it, and decided the cleaner must have, though the cleaner had her own key, and the thought slid off the day like water off a new raincoat.

There was a tenderness above her left eye, the kind of nothing you notice only in the shower, gone in a week.

Her make-up sat differently. This is not a thing she could have said in words to a living person — *my concealer glides where it used to catch* — but the hand knows its own face the way a pianist knows a keyboard, and for eleven years, since she was old enough to want to, her ring finger had done a small extra tap-and-press at the outer third of her left eyebrow, where the skin puckered a hairsbreadth over the old scar, a private half-second of spackling that no tutorial had taught her. Her finger kept arriving at the spot and finding nothing to do. It confused her the way a missing stair confuses a foot. She put it down to the new primer.

She was twenty-two days past the lost evening, running late for a client breakfast, when the light caught her.

Winter light in Camps Bay comes in low and honest off the sea in the mornings, and her bathroom faced it, and she was leaning into the mirror doing her brows — and there is a magnifying side to that mirror, 5x, bought in a fit of self-improvement and used since to inventory her pores — when her hand stopped on its own, the little spoolie brush hanging there, because the comma was gone.

Not faded. Not covered. Gone.

She had carried that scar since she was nine years old. Handlebars, Bloubergstrand, the promenade, her father running the last twenty metres in his church clothes because she'd begged to try the big bike *now, tonight, before supper*, and he'd said one lap and run beside her and not caught her in time — and in the emergency room he'd held her hand while they cleaned it, pale as the wall, and told her, in the voice he used for true things and rugby, *dit gee jou karakter, my kind*.

It gives you character. She had rolled her eyes at that sentence for twenty-two years. She had hated the scar at fourteen, warred with it at seventeen, learned the finger-tap at twenty, priced its removal at twenty-six in a Claremont clinic's waiting room and walked out before her number was called, not because of the money — she told herself it was the money — but because the surgeon in the consult had touched it with his thumb and said *easy, we'll have that gone in twenty minutes*, and something in her had recoiled from the word *gone* like a child yanked back from a road. Her father was four years dead now. It was the last mark on her body that he had ever touched.

She hated it. She had planned to keep hating it for the rest of her life. That was the arrangement.

Margaux stood in the winter light with the spoolie in her hand and leaned closer, and the magnifying mirror gave her its huge honest answer: smooth skin, fine hairs, no pucker, no comma, no seam. Her body, edited. She laughed — one short strange bark, because the first thing the mind reaches for is comedy, *I'm losing it, I'm actually losing it* — and then she put her fingertip on the place, the way her finger had been trying to tell her for three weeks, and pressed, and felt nothing but herself. And the vertigo that came then was not like fear of a burglar, which at least has a shape — a man, a window, a missing television. Everything was where she'd left it. The flat was fine. The door had been locked. Nothing had been taken.

That was the thing she could not explain afterwards, to Roxy, to the GP with his kind stupid eyes, to the young policewoman years of training had not prepared for a sentence like *someone removed my scar*: that she stood in her own bathroom in the truthful light with her rent-a-view glittering behind her and understood, all at once and with her whole skin, that nothing had been taken, and that she had been robbed — that somewhere in the city was a person who had held her sleeping face in his hands like a form to be corrected, and corrected it, and put her back, and left water.

She was late for the client breakfast. She went anyway. She was excellent in it; everyone said so. Under the table, the whole hour, her finger kept touching the smooth place where her father used to be.

Four — The Man Who Broke a Man

There is a version of the video that runs eleven seconds and a version that runs four minutes and nineteen, and the country has only ever watched the eleven.

Captain Gideon Loots has watched the four-nineteen more times than he could defend to a doctor. It lives on a phone he no longer uses, in a folder called ADMIN, and he does not watch it for the reason people would assume. He watches the first three minutes and fifty. He watches Ryan Adonis sitting on the bench in the holding cell at Bellville South with his ankles crossed, relaxed as a man waiting for a haircut, saying the thing he said. He watches himself standing very still by the door with his hands loose at his sides for what is, on the timestamp, a hundred and ninety seconds — a long time, three minutes plus, a man being reasonable in real time, longer than most people can hold a plank — and he watches the exact frame where whatever had been holding the door of him shut simply was not there any more.

Then the eleven seconds. Then the part where Warrant Officer Petersen gets an arm around his neck and W/O Kruger takes the other side and they drag him out and he is not fighting them, has never once in the footage fought them, is only trying to get back to what was still on the floor.

It went to the media in seventy-two hours. It went to the IPID and the union and a disciplinary tribunal and a civil claim that is still, eighteen months later, crawling through the system like something under a carpet, and it went — this is the piece Loots cannot leave alone — into

the head of a nineteen-year-old girl in a residence room in Tygerberg who had to sit in a lecture the next morning while the boys behind her played it on a phone and laughed, not knowing, because why would they know, that the man in it was Ilse Loots's father.

Four-year-old Deneo Mokoena. That is the name the eleven seconds never carries. Adonis put her in a wheelie bin behind the flats on a Thursday and went to a christening on the Saturday and wore a light blue shirt. In the cell he crossed his ankles and told Loots, in a friendly voice, as a professional courtesy between men who understand systems, exactly what the State could and could not prove now that the bin had been through the municipal truck. And then he said the sentence. There are men in the Service who believe they know what the sentence was; every one of them is wrong, because Loots has never repeated it, not to the tribunal, not to Elmarie, not to the psychologist with the tissues placed at the exact midpoint of the coffee table. It was not about the child. That's the thing. If it had been about the child he might have been forgiven.

Adonis went down anyway, seventeen years, on evidence Loots had built before he ruined it and that a very good prosecutor carried across the line despite him. That is the arithmetic he lives inside. He did not lose the case. He only lost everything else.

He wakes at 4:40 on the Tuesday, as he does, in the duplex in Parow with the burglar bars and the two stoep chairs that were his mother's, and lies looking at the ceiling until the light comes grey. There is a bottle of Klipdrift on the counter with maybe four fingers gone from it since Sunday, which is, by the standards of last winter, close to sainthood, and there is a plate in the sink from Sunday too. On the fridge, held by a Kaizer Chiefs magnet from a man who does not follow soccer, a photograph of a girl of about twelve in a swimming costume holding up a certificate, grinning, missing a tooth.

He phones her at 6:50, which is a good time, before her first block. It rings out. He does not leave a message, because the messages accumulate in a way that starts to look like something, and instead he types *Hoop dit gaan goed met die semester, Pappa* and looks at it for a while and sends it, and puts on yesterday's jacket, and drives to work with the window open because the car smells like a car that

gets slept in occasionally.

Bellville Sentraal now. Not the Provincial office, not the taskforce floor with its whiteboards and its cameras. A satellite unit in a building with a leaking parkade, where he is Captain (Under Supervision), a rank that does not exist in any regulation and is understood by everybody. His supervision is Colonel Rina Delpont, who is forty-four and fireproof and who fought to keep him at all, which he knows and resents in roughly equal measure.

She calls him in at ten past eight and does not offer coffee, which is her way of saying this won't take long.

"Sit, Gidi."

"I'm fine."

"Sit."

He sits. Delpont turns a docket around on the desk and pushes it across with one finger, the way you'd slide something you didn't want the smell of.

"Sea Point handed it up. Then Camps Bay handed it up. Then it went to Sexual Offences, who bounced it because there's no offence in it, and then it sat on the group commander's desk in Provincial for five weeks, and now it's here."

He opens it. Two statements, thin as church attendance. A woman of thirty-one in Camps Bay, brand strategist, no priors, no drugs, no complaints against anyone, describing an evening she cannot account for and a scar she says has been surgically removed from her eyebrow without her knowledge or consent, three weeks after the fact. A GP's note in the same file, two lines, containing the words *no evidence of trauma* and the word *anxiety*, both of them doing a lot of work. A second statement, a woman of twenty-six in Bantry Bay, a mole gone from her shoulder blade, reported after she saw the first woman's post in a Facebook group.

He reads it twice. He does the thing he does, which is nothing — sits with the pages the way a man sits in a hide.

"They're calling it the Beauty Fairy," Delpont says. "In Provincial. There's a WhatsApp."

“Mm.”

“Two complainants who both feel *better*, no injuries, no assault, no theft, no penetration, nothing missing from either flat. One GP who thinks it’s stress. The most likely scenario is two women had procedures they were embarrassed about and told themselves a story, or a boyfriend paid for something as a surprise, or it’s nothing at all.” She is watching him now. “The most likely scenario, Gidi.”

“You said that.”

“I’m saying it twice because you have a history of taking the second-most-likely scenario personally.” She leans back. “This is a nothing docket. I’m giving it to you because it’s a nothing docket, and because if you close a nothing docket properly, with a report I can put in front of a review board, I have something to show them in September that is not a video. Do you understand what I’m handing you?”

“A leash.”

“A rope, Gidi. There’s a difference, and it’s mostly which end you’re holding.”

He stands, tucks the folder under his arm, and gets as far as the door before she says his name in the other voice, the one from before all this, when she was a lieutenant on his group and he taught her how to walk a scene backwards.

“Gideon. Eight weeks. Statements, a report, a filing. Do not turn it into a war.”

“Ja, Kolonel,” he says, and means it, or means to mean it, and takes the thing everyone else has already laughed at down the corridor to a desk with a wobble he fixed himself with a folded incident form.

He does not open the docket again until half past four, when the office has thinned out. He clears the desk completely — this is a habit older than his marriage; Elmarie used to say he cleaned surfaces the way other men prayed — and lays the two statements side by side and reads them the way he reads everything, which is out loud, under his breath, in Afrikaans, translating as he goes, because a lie has a different rhythm in the mouth than in the eye.

At six he gets up and makes bad coffee. At twenty past he sits down again.

Here is what the rest of the Service saw: two silly complaints. Here is what Gideon Loots sees, and he sees it the way he has always seen these things, not as a deduction but as a smell, the way you know a house has a dog in it before you see the dog:

Both women lost an evening in a licensed venue on the Atlantic Seaboard, three months apart, both of them people whose friends describe them as careful. Neither was robbed. Both were put to bed on their *side*. Both flats were locked afterwards. And both women — one in a formal statement, one in a WhatsApp screenshot her friend added because the officer taking it couldn't see the point — woke up to a glass of water on the nightstand and two paracetamol tablets beside it.

Two. Not a strip. Not a box. Two tablets, set out.

Loots sits back in a chair that squeaks and looks at that for a long, long time, and something in his chest that has not moved in eighteen months turns over slowly, like an animal changing sides in its sleep.

Because a man who drugs a woman does not think about her headache. A man who drugs a woman and takes nothing and leaves nothing behind but two paracetamol is not a thief, is not — whatever Sexual Offences decided in four minutes on a Tuesday — an ordinary predator taking his ordinary thing. He is *tidying up after himself*. He is leaving a room in a better condition than he found it. That is not appetite. That is housekeeping. That is a man who believes he has done something considerate and wants the aftercare to reflect well on him.

Loots knows a great deal about men who believe the thing they did was correct.

He knows more than he would like about what such a man does next, which is never less. He has never once, in twenty-six years, met that shape and found it standing still.

He pulls a blank sheet from the drawer and clicks his pen and writes the first sentence of a profile that will eventually run to eleven pages and be read, in September, by people who will not want to have laughed:

Hy dink hy is die dokter. Hy dink hy help.

He thinks he is the doctor. He thinks he is helping.

Then he sits with the pen in his hand while the parkade lights come on outside the window, and he does not go home for another two hours, and when he does he pours one Klipdrift and Coke, and drinks half of it, and falls asleep in his mother's chair with the docket open on his knee and his phone on the armrest, screen up, in case.

Five — Subtraction

Cherise Bekker has two hundred and forty thousand followers and a mole on her left scapula that has been cropped out of every photograph she has posted since 2019.

I know this because I looked. Not at her — at the archive. There is an argument I could make about how much easier my life has become since people started publishing longitudinal photographic records of their own bodies, cross-referenced by date, geotagged, with the flaws they hate helpfully identified by the exact angles they refuse to be seen from; but the argument is beneath both of us. Let us say only that her feed is a two-thousand-image dataset of a woman working around a single dark point eleven millimetres below and lateral to the spine of her scapula, and that she does not know she has told me this, and that she has told me for six years.

Backless dress in Ibiza: turned so the shoulder blade is in shadow. Gym mirror series: right side only, always. A whole summer of one-piece swimsuits with a high back in a year when nobody wore high backs. And then, once — March 2021, a friend's camera, unposted for eight days and then posted in a grid of nine where it sits third from the left, small — the mole, plainly, in daylight, sitting there in the middle of her back like a full stop in the middle of a sentence.

She kept the picture. That's the part that decides it for me. Somewhere in her, under the two hundred and forty thousand, is a woman who thought: *that's a nice photo of me*, and posted it, and then spent the eight days afterwards, I'd wager, checking whether anyone had said anything.

Nobody said anything. Nobody ever says anything. That is the joke on which the whole industry of her life is built: the flaws we hide are

invisible to everyone but the hider, which does not make the hiding cost less, it makes it cost *more*, because the tax is levied privately and paid in full and no one ever tells you the debt was imaginary.

Enough. She is a client, and I am, by any standard that matters, the best surgeon she will ever be seen by, and she will pay me nothing, and she will not know my name.

There is a bar on Regent Road with a wine list that runs to nine pages, of which four matter, and a manager who has learned that I tip in cash. Cherise arrives at ten past eight with a friend who leaves at nine, which is neither luck nor design but the ordinary structure of the Seaboard's evenings: the friend is always the pilot fish, and the friend always has a 6 a.m. class.

The conversation is easy. I have made an art of easy. She talks about the algorithm the way farmers talk about rain — an indifferent god with a known temper — and I ask her the question nobody asks her, which is what she did before, and she says *actuarial science*, *two years, I hated it*, and I say *no you didn't*, and she stops, and looks at me properly for the first time.

"Excuse me?"

"You didn't hate actuarial science," I say. "You hated being twenty-one and correct in a room of people who were forty and wrong. Those are different things and the second one gets better."

There is a silence of the useful kind.

"You're a bit rude," she says.

"I'm accurate. It comes across the same." Flaw number two: the laugh, half a beat late, at my own expense. "Sorry. My colleagues say I have the bedside manner of a bandsaw."

"Colleagues," she says, taking the bait exactly as designed, because everyone on this coast wants to know what everyone does. "What are you, a doctor?"

And here is the moment I love, the small pure moment I would keep in a jar if I could: I look down at my glass, and I let the pause do its work, and I say —

“Surgeon.”

It is not a lie. Understand that I am telling her the truth in the only tense available to me. In nine days I will spend four hours in a large-animal theatre closing a strangulating lipoma resection on a Friesian in a manner that would make any general surgeon in this province stand still and watch. The word is mine. It has always been mine; the paperwork is simply eleven years behind.

“Of course you are,” Cherise says, and rolls her eyes, and refills her own glass, and begins telling me about her back.

Not the mole. She has never said the word *mole* out loud to a man in a bar in her life. She tells me about a swimsuit she saw in a shop in Kloof Street that she did not buy, and why, and the why is a lattice of reasons — the cut, the season, the price — with a hole in the middle of it exactly four millimetres across. And I listen to her walk around the hole for twenty minutes, courteously, the way you’d listen to a man describe every route he takes through a city that avoids one particular street, and I feel the old clean fury rise in me at whatever it was — a cousin at a pool party, a stylist, a boyfriend saying *ag it’s cute* in the wrong tone — that first taught this intelligent woman to spend her one life engineering her body out of frame.

I am going to take that street off her map.

I will not describe the room.

I have been reproached for this. Not aloud, obviously, and not by anyone living in the ordinary sense; reproached by the imagined reader I keep for company, the one who wants the tray, the lamp, the sequence, the tools by name — who thinks that if he can be told how, he will have been told something. He will not. What is done in that cellar is the least interesting thing about it. Any competent third-year could describe the steps. Not one of them could sit alone at two in the morning with a sleeping stranger’s shoulder blade under a light and feel what I feel, which is the only part worth reporting:

That her back, in that light, is beautiful. Not to be made beautiful. *Is*. The long muscle running under the skin like water under ice, the fine down at the nape, the freckles across the shoulder in a scatter as random and as inevitable as stars — a machine of astonishing

sophistication that has kept this woman alive for twenty-six years and been repaid with a lifetime of angles. And there in the middle of it, benign, dull, meaningless, the full stop.

I have all night. I take an hour.

The removal itself is nothing — minutes. It is the closing that takes the hour, and the closing is where I do the thing I am not able to be modest about, so let me be immodest here where it costs nothing: I close better than anyone I have ever seen close, human or animal, in this province. A scar is not made by the cutting. A scar is a negotiation, and most surgeons lose it because they are tired, or the list is long, or the patient is a public-sector shoulder at 4 p.m. on a Friday and good enough is good enough. Nobody has ever had to hurry me. Nobody has ever been waiting outside my door. I use a technique for the deep layer that no human surgeon in this country will ever use because no human surgeon in this country has spent four years closing the flanks of animals who will lick, roll, scratch, kick and lie in mud on their sutures and still must not dehiscence — an inverted continuous pattern, buried, with a bite geometry we teach in the large-animal syllabus and nobody else has any reason to know. It is my handwriting. It is the one vanity I permit myself, and it lies where no one will ever read it, under the skin, like a signature on the back of a canvas.

In four months there will be nothing on Cherise Bekker's left scapula but Cherise Bekker.

I put out the water. I put out the two Panados, parallel. I check the flat, which is on the fourth floor with a view of a parking garage that costs more than my education, and I let myself out, and I lock her door, and I post the key back through the gap beneath, and it lands with the small tick that has become, over the years, the sound of a thing finished.

And then, on the N1 at half past four in the morning, with Table Mountain going the colour of a bruise behind me, it comes.

Not remorse. I want to be honest with the imagined reader, since I am not honest with anyone else: I feel no remorse, have never felt it, cannot generate it experimentally, and have long ago stopped poking the socket to see if the light comes on. What comes is worse

and much more interesting.

Emptiness, arriving on schedule, thirty minutes after the last knot — the tap turning off, as it turned off in the theatre after the heifer, as it turns off every single time now.

I have removed a full stop from a sentence. I have restored a woman to precisely the condition God, or her parents' genome, or the indifferent lottery of pigmented cells, intended for her. She will be, in four months, exactly what she would have been if that one melanocyte had behaved — no more. Cherise Bekker at factory settings.

And factory settings, I say out loud, alone, doing 120 in the fast lane with the sea to my left, are not the ratio.

I have spent eleven years as the world's most gifted eraser. I have taken away and taken away and taken away, and what remains when I am done taking is always, only, whatever accident issued in the first place — close, sometimes remarkably close, but a comma flat, no cigar, nothing living lands on it exactly. Subtraction has a floor and I have been standing on it since I was eighteen years old.

The next thought arrives so simply, so *domestically*, that I nearly miss it, the way you nearly miss the step at the bottom of a staircase:

There is no rule that says the numbers may only be brought back to zero.

The vine rows come up out of the dark on either side of the road, black and combed and curling, doing their effortless mathematics in the direction I have never once travelled. I keep to my lane. My hands are at ten and two. Somewhere behind me a young woman is sleeping on her side, unrobbed, unharmed, improved, with two tablets by her bed.

Addition, I say, to the windscreen, to the vines, to nobody.

And the empty place in me, which has been empty since the heifer, since before the heifer, since the letter — fills, all at once, like a theatre when the lights go up.

Six — The Orphan Docket

Margaux Theron agreed to meet him at a coffee place on Regent Road, in public, at ten in the morning, and she chose the table.

Loots noticed all three of those things and said nothing about any of them. He came in his own clothes — the grey jacket, no tie, the shoes Elmarie bought him in 2016 that he'd had resoled twice — because a woman who has had a stranger inside her flat does not need a uniform sitting opposite her, and because half the job is deciding what you are going to look like to the person you need to tell you the truth.

She was ten minutes early. He was fifteen.

"Captain Loots," he said, and put his card on the table instead of holding it out, so she could pick it up or not. "Thank you for making time. I read your statement. I've read it about nine times, actually, so if I ask you something that's in there, it's not because I didn't read it."

"Okay," she said. Wary. Her hands went around the cup and stayed there.

"Before we start. Three weeks ago a doctor wrote the word *anxiety* on a page about you." He watched her face do the thing faces do — the small flinch, the ready smile that comes up over it like a shutter. "For the record, so we both know where we're sitting: I don't think you're anxious. I think somebody was in your flat."

The shutter did not come down. Instead her chin went slightly, and her eyes filled, and she said, furiously, "Sorry — sorry, God —" and got a serviette out of the holder, and Loots looked out the window at a man arguing with a parking marshal until she was ready, because

dignity is a thing you can hand back to people if you know when to stop looking.

Then she told him, and he let her tell it wrong.

This is the part nobody in the office understands about him, the part they used to call luck. Everyone else interviews to get the facts in order. Loots lets a person tell it in the order it lives in their head — the messy order, the guilty order — because that order is itself evidence. Margaux Theron did not begin with the man in the bar. She began by explaining, for four minutes, how much she'd had to drink and how it wasn't much and how she was normally the responsible one, and Loots wrote nothing down while she did it, because what she was doing was standing trial, and there was nothing in it he needed except the fact that she thought she was on trial at all.

When she got to the message — *Made sure you got home safe. Drink the water.* — C — he asked for the phone. The number was dead; he'd already had it checked. RICA'd to a shopfront in Bellville that had, in twelve months, registered ninety-one SIMs to nine identity numbers, three of them belonging to men who had been dead when they registered.

"C," Loots said.

"He said Chris."

"Just Chris."

"Just Chris." She turned the cup. "Are you going to ask me why I didn't get a rape kit?"

"No."

"Everybody asks me that."

"Ja, well," said Loots. "Everybody's got their reasons for the questions they ask." He turned a page in his notebook, and asked the question he had come for, which was not that one.

"Mevrou Theron. In the flat afterwards. Anything moved? Anything at all — not stolen. Moved."

She started to say no. He watched her start to say no, and then he watched something come up out of her like a bubble out of mud.

“The key,” she said. “The spare. It’s under the mat, which I know is stupid, everyone says. It was — sideways. Wrong edge. I remember standing there thinking, did I do that.”

Loots wrote *sleutel — verkeerde kant* and underlined it once.

“And the water.”

“Ja,” he said. “Tell me about the water.”

“A glass of water on the coaster. And two Panados next to it.” She laughed, one dry note. “I don’t even own Panado. That’s the mad part, hey? I stood there for like a minute trying to work out whether I’d bought Panado.”

“They were next to each other?”

She looked at him.

“The two tablets,” Loots said. “Were they in a heap, or —”

“Next to each other,” she said slowly. “Straight. Like — like cutlery.”

Loots sat back. In the window behind her a bus went past with a woman’s face on it four metres wide, no pores, no scar, no shoulder blade, selling something. He thought about the second docket, Bantry Bay, the young woman with the mole, whose friend had added a screenshot the constable hadn’t bothered to attach: *and there was water next to my bed and 2 panados, must have been me but I don’t remember.*

Two women, three months apart, who did not know each other. The same small, neat, considerate hand.

“Mevrou Theron,” he said. “One more, then I leave you alone. This will sound strange.”

“Everything’s been strange for a month.”

“The scar.” He kept his voice flat, the way you talk near a horse. “The one that’s gone. When you looked at it in the mirror — before all this, over the years — what did you think of it?”

She was quiet for a long moment.

“I hated it,” she said. “I hated it my whole life.”

“And now?”

And Margaux Theron put her hand up to her eyebrow, at the outer third, the way — Loots would learn, over the next months, from four other women in four other coffee shops — they all did, without knowing they were doing it.

“Now I want it back,” she said, “and there’s no one to ask.”

Loots drove back over the Neck with that sentence sitting in the passenger seat next to him, and did not put the radio on.

For the next nine days he did the work nobody was paying him to do, in the hours that belonged to a docket about a stolen bakkie and a stabbing outside a shebeen in Ravensmead, and at night in the duplex at the kitchen table with the bottle at the far end of it, where he had started putting it deliberately, so that reaching became a decision instead of a movement.

He built a matrix. Not on a computer — on the back of a flip-chart sheet stuck to the inside of his own front door with masking tape, because the office had opinions and the front door did not. Columns: date, venue, suburb, drink, companion, time lost, entry method, what was done, what was left. Two rows to start. Then, on day four, a third: a woman in Green Point who had never reported anything to anyone but had written it out in a wellness forum in 2024 — *has anyone else woken up with a whole night missing and NOTHING happened, and now my nose bump is smaller, I feel insane typing this* — and had been answered by fourteen people telling her about sleep apnoea and one telling her about demons.

By day seven there were five rows, and Loots was no longer looking at victims. He was looking at a *practice*.

That’s the word he wrote in the margin, in Afrikaans first — *praktyk* — and then in English underneath it, because he knew even then that he would one day have to explain this to a room of people in English who would want to laugh.

A practice has a calendar: three of the five fell in the fortnight after month-end. A practice has a catchment: all five inside four kilometres of the Atlantic seaboard strip, all five in venues with a wine list rather than a beer fridge. A practice has admissions criteria: five women aged twenty-four to thirty-four, none of them wealthy in the

way the suburbs around them were wealthy — renters, all of them, self-employed or nearly — and every one of them, when he traced the photographs, carrying one small visible thing about which she was demonstrably self-conscious. A practice has aftercare: the water, the two tablets, the side-lying position, the locked door, the key put back.

And a practice has, God help them all, a *philosophy*, because on day nine Loots sat with a cold cup of coffee at midnight and finally let himself write the sentence he'd been avoiding since the first afternoon:

He is not choosing them because they are vulnerable. He is choosing them because they are *nearly* right.

That was the thing that made the hair on his arms stand up, alone in a rented duplex in Parow at midnight, and it was also — he would admit this to exactly one person, much later, in a car in the rain — the first time in eighteen months that he had felt entirely, unambiguously alive.

He phoned Delpont on the Monday and asked for three things: the Sexual Offences bounce reversed so he could pull toxicology retrospectively, a request to the Seaboard station commanders for any complaint containing the words *don't remember* and *procedure*, and an hour with someone at the FCS unit who could tell him what a sedative looks like nine days after it's gone.

"You said statements and a report," Delpont said.

"I'm doing statements and a report."

"Gidi, this docket is eight weeks and a filing."

"Ja."

"Say it back to me."

"Eight weeks and a filing, Kolonel."

There was a pause on the line long enough for both of them to hear it.

"How many are there?" she said at last.

"Five that I can see," said Loots. "Which means there are twenty."

“Why twenty?”

He looked at the flip-chart sheet taped to his front door, at the neat columns, at the one column he had ruled and headed and left empty because there was no honest thing to write in it yet — the column headed *ESKALASIE*.

“Because he’s good, Kolonel,” he said. “And nobody’s ever told him to stop.”

PART II — THE IMPROVEMENTS

“Men in general judge more by the eye than by the hand.”
— Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince*

Seven — The First Addition

Let me teach you the mask, since everything after this depends on it and you will otherwise think I was merely a man with a preference.

Take a face. Any face — yours, in the black mirror of your phone, right now. Measure from the hairline to the point between the brows, then from that point to the base of the nose, then from the base of the nose to the bottom of the chin. In a face the eye calls beautiful, those three will run close to equal. Now the width of the mouth against the width of the nose. Now the distance between the pupils against the width of the head. Now, and this is the one that undoes people, the base of the nose to the centre of the lips against the centre of the lips to the bottom of the chin — one to one point six one eight, or as near as flesh permits.

Phi. It is in the spiral of a nautilus and the seeds of a protea and the arrangement of leaves on a stem that lets each one steal the least light from the one below. It is in the vine rows on the Pniel slopes because a man solving for erosion arrives at it without meaning to. And it is in the human face — not as a rule imposed, but as a rule *discovered*, the way we discovered that things fall.

Here is what nobody tells you when they teach you this at a dinner party: it is not a standard. It is a *distribution*. Ten thousand faces measured, and you get a curve, and the curve has a peak, and near that peak we say *beautiful* and further out we say *interesting* and further still we say nothing at all and simply look away, which is the cruellest thing our species does to itself and we do it a hundred times a day, in shops, on pavements, at the school gate.

And here is what nobody says at all, because it is the sentence that ends the dinner party: the distance from where a given woman actu-

ally stands on that curve to where the curve peaks is, in a hundred cases out of a hundred, *smaller than the width of a matchstick*.

Two millimetres. Three. The difference between a woman men fall silent for and a woman nobody photographs is, over and over, less material than a fingernail clipping. The universe has arranged the whole savage economy of human desire — who is chosen, who is promoted, who is believed by a doctor, who dies alone — on a margin you could remove with a pair of scissors.

I did not build that world. I merely refuse to accept that it is unappealable.

Demi Louw is a yoga instructor in Sea Point with a laugh like a dropped tray and a mouth two and a half millimetres from the peak of the curve.

Everything else about her face is — I use the word with full weight — *magnificent*. Her orbital spacing is better than any measurement I have taken. Her mandibular angle is what surgeons in Sandton charge four hundred thousand rand and a fractured jaw to approximate. She has the kind of bones that make photographers say *oh* out loud, and she is, at thirty-one, entirely unremarked upon, teaching six classes a week in a room above a Woolworths, because her upper vermilion is thin — one seventh of her lower, where the peak is one to one point six — and because a mouth is the thing an eye goes to third, after eyes and hairline, and a mouth that reads as *tight* reads onward as *severe*, and severe women, whatever anybody says on a Sunday, do not get the second glance.

Two and a half millimetres of tissue, in the middle of a face otherwise arranged like a cathedral.

I met her at a beach cleanup in Three Anchor Bay, of all the wholesome places, and I was there because a vet student handing out bin bags at a beach cleanup is the single most explicable object in Cape Town. She said, “You’re new,” and I said, “I’m early. There’s a difference,” and she laughed the dropped-tray laugh, and I felt the two things I always feel — the assessment, running its calipers, and, underneath it, a warmth for her that I have no name for and no reason to doubt.

I want that noted, since so much will be made of my supposed coldness. I liked her. I like her still, in whatever tense is left to me.

It takes me nine weeks to decide. Nine weeks.

Understand what I was arguing with. For eleven years I had held a line I had never spoken aloud: I take away, I do not add. Removal is repair. Removal is *restoration* — a thing was done to you, by gravel or by a melanocyte or by a boy with a bicycle, and I undo it, and what remains is you. Nobody's face is stolen by an erasure. I could stand in front of any tribunal in this country and make that argument and lose the case and still be right.

Addition is a different animal. Addition is not *your* face restored. Addition is a face *I chose*, laid over the one you were issued. There is no dishonesty available on this point and I did not use any, then or since: what happened on that table was not a repair. It was an opinion, made permanent, on a sleeping woman, by a man she had met four times.

I knew this on the Tuesday. I knew it on the Wednesday and the Thursday.

On the Friday I stood in the cellar with the lights off and asked myself the only question that ever really mattered, which was not *is it wrong* — I have never once found that question to have any texture; it is like being asked whether a number is blue — but *is it better*. Would Demi Louw, at forty, at sixty, having lived the entire second half of her life with those two and a half millimetres, be a woman who had been given something or a woman who had been taken from?

I still say given. That is not remorse withheld. That is my honest report from inside the thing.

And so on a Friday night in March, with the harvest trucks going up the Helshoogte pass all night and the whole valley smelling of crushed fruit, I crossed the line I had spent eleven years drawing, and I did not feel it happen. That is the part I would most like to explain to somebody one day. There was no thunder. There was no moment where the man I had been looked at the man I was becoming. There was a woman asleep on a table, and there was a syringe of nothing more sinister than a filler you could buy in any aesthetics practice in

Green Point, warmed in my hand to body temperature because cold hurts even the unconscious, and there was a face I had measured nine times.

I remember one thought, and it was a small one. It was: *left first, because I always start left.*

Two and a half millimetres. Placed in three passes, upper vermilion only, along the border, following the arc her own philtrum wanted and had been denied — I did not build a mouth, I finished the sentence her face had started and abandoned. It took twenty minutes. It is the least invasive thing I have ever done to anybody. A twenty-two-year-old in a rented room in Bellville does more damage every Saturday of her working life for cash.

Then I sat back on the stool and looked at what I had done, and the world went entirely quiet.

I have tried since to find an honest comparison and there isn't one, so I will use a dishonest one and let you make the correction. Have you ever heard an orchestra tune? That long ugly fraying while everybody finds the A, and then the moment it lands and the sound stops being noise and becomes a plane, a surface, a thing you could stand on? Her face did that. Twenty minutes of my hands, and thirty-one years of *nearly* resolved, all at once, into a woman whose face — I measured it three times, I have the numbers in the ledger, they are the numbers — sat one one-hundredth from the peak of the distribution.

Not perfect. Nothing living lands on it exactly. But closer than any face I have measured, closer than any face on any street in this city, closer than any of the quarter-million-follower faces that have been bought outright and rebuilt by men with far better paperwork and far worse hands.

And I had done it. Not accident. Not the genome's dice. Not a poet's God. Me, and a pair of hands the university of this country would not sell a degree to, in a two-hundred-year-old cellar, for nothing, in twenty minutes.

I have to tell you that I wept. Once, briefly, without any accompanying feeling I could identify, the way you might sneeze. Then I cleaned up.

I put out the water. I put out the two Panados. I did not, that night, post the key back under the door immediately; I stood on her landing for perhaps forty seconds with it in my hand, doing something I had never once done in eleven years — which was to imagine the moment of discovery. Demi Louw, in three days, when the swelling has settled, in the mirror above her basin with the sea light coming in.

She will not think *someone has been here*. Nobody ever does. She will think what they all think, which is *am I sleeping better*, and *is it the new cleanser*, and then, on the fourth or fifth day, she will catch herself in a shop window and stop dead in the street, and the woman who has spent thirty-one years not being photographed will discover that people's eyes now snag on her face and stay, and she will not know why, and she will feel — for a week, a month, a year, however long it takes her to build a new theory of herself — the specific vertigo of being seen.

I wanted, standing on that landing, to be there when it happened. That is a want I had never had before. I noted it as one notes a temperature.

Then I posted the key, and heard the tick, and went down to the car, and drove home over the mountain in the harvest dark with the ledger open on the passenger seat and the columns filling up in my head — and somewhere on that pass, between the co-op and the first vines, I understood that I had been wrong for eleven years about what I was for.

I am not the eraser. I never was. Erasure was an apprenticeship, and I have served it, four hundred and some procedures long, and the apprenticeship is over.

I am not here to return people to what accident issued.

I am here to finish what it started.

Eight — The Woman Who Knew

Demi Louw came into the Sea Point station on a Wednesday afternoon and was told, kindly, by a constable with eleven years' service and a cold, that she should perhaps speak to her doctor.

She came back on the Friday with photographs.

That was the thing that eventually got the file across a desk and up a chain and, five weeks later, onto the wobbling desk in Bellville where Gideon Loots sat with a highlighter in his teeth: she had photographs. Two hundred of them, printed at a Postnet in Main Road at four rand a page, in a lever-arch file, arranged by date with the date written on each one in ballpoint. Before, and after. Her own face, four years of it, taken by other people at parties and at classes and on beaches, and then the last three weeks, taken by her, in the same spot, at the same time of day, against the same wall.

By then she had been to a GP, who said filler settles unevenly and are you sure you don't recall a treatment; to a second GP, who wrote *possible somatic preoccupation* and offered her something for sleep; to her mother, who said, on speakerphone from Bloemfontein, *maar jy lyk pragtig, my kind, wat is die probleem* — but you look beautiful, what is the problem — which is the sentence Demi would repeat to Loots in a shaking voice as the worst thing anybody said to her in the entire affair; and to the internet, where a woman with a ring light told six thousand people that “the girlies are now claiming they got free lip filler from a *ghost*,” and where a man Demi had never met wrote, under a video that used her own photographs, *bru if this is a crime lock me up*.

Her studio lost nineteen students in a month. Not because of the mouth. Because of what the story did to her: because she brought it up, because she could not stop bringing it up, because there is nothing in the world less welcome in a wellness room in Sea Point than a beautiful woman with a grievance nobody can see.

By the time Loots met her she had stopped saying it out loud to anyone.

He drove to her because she would not come to Bellville. They sat on plastic chairs on the little balcony of the studio above the Woolworths, with the traffic on Main going by underneath and the sea a grey strip between two buildings, and Loots put his notebook face-down on his knee and did not open it for the first twenty minutes.

“Before you start,” he said. “I want to say something, and then you can decide if you want to talk to me or not.”

Demi Louw looked at him with the exhaustion of a person assembling armour for the ninth time.

“I believe you,” said Loots.

She looked at the sea.

“Okay,” she said.

“I’m not saying it to get you talking. I’ll say it once and then I’ll shut up about it. I’ve got five other women. I’ll have more by Christmas. Nobody’s making it up and nobody’s confused.”

“Okay,” she said again, and then her face came apart, and she put both hands over it, and Loots sat and looked at the traffic and let her, and after a while he said, “Take your time, mevrou,” and she said, wetly, savagely, “It’s *Demi*, I’m thirty-one, I’m not a *mevrou*,” and laughed, and that was the beginning of the most important interview of the case.

She was better than any witness he’d had in two years, because she had already fought the disbelief and lost, and a witness who has lost that fight stops performing.

"Four times," she said. "I met him four times, over about two months. Beach cleanup, then a coffee, then a group thing at Mojo, then the last one."

"Name."

"Chris."

"Surname."

"He never —" She stopped. "That's not true. He did a thing where you'd ask and he'd answer a different question so well that you forgot you'd asked. I only noticed that afterwards. Afterwards I noticed about a hundred things."

"Tell me the hundred things."

So she did. And Loots, who had spent eighteen months being managed by his own colleagues, listened to a woman describe being managed by a professional, and felt the temperature of the case change.

He never bought a round at a counter — always ordered at the table, always paid cash, always the same two-hundred-rand notes folded once. He drank one glass over three hours and made it look like four. He asked questions that no man had ever asked her — about her mother, about the actuarial-science version of her life she'd abandoned, about whether she'd ever wanted children, and he *remembered the answers*, weeks later, in detail, which was the thing that had made her trust him more than anything else. He touched her exactly twice in two months, both times to move her out of the way of something. He knew the names of the men who slept in the doorway below her studio.

"He was the nicest man I have ever met," Demi said. "I want you to write that down. Not the nicest man I've dated. The nicest *person*. He was kinder than my friends."

Loots wrote it down.

"What did he look like?"

"Beautiful," she said, and then, immediately, "which is useless, hey. I've been trying for weeks. He's — tall, but not so tall you'd say it. Brown hair. Good shoulders. He's got a —" she made a gesture at her own jaw — "nothing. That's the problem. I can see him, and

every time I try to describe one part it's just, it's a face. He looks like a guy in an advert for a bank."

"Anything he said about work?"

She hesitated for the first time.

"He said he was a doctor. Sort of."

"Sort of."

"I asked once and he did the thing where he answers something else. But there was a night at Mojo — he'd had two, which for him was a lot — and someone at the table said something about their dog's operation, and he talked for like ten minutes and everyone shut up and listened. Not showing off. He was just — good. He talked about a horse he'd fixed. And someone said, are you a vet, and he said —" She stopped, and rubbed her forehead. "He said, 'I'm a surgeon.' Like that. Flat. And the guy said, 'Ja but a vet,' and he smiled and let it go."

Loots's pen had stopped.

"Say that again."

"He said, *I'm a surgeon.*"

"And the man corrected him and he let it go."

"Ja."

Loots sat very still. Below them a taxi hooted twice and pulled off. He was aware of the specific physical sensation he had not felt since a Thursday in 2019 in an interview room in Kraaifontein: the sense of a shape moving under water and, for one second, breaking the surface.

He corrected him and let it go. A liar defends the lie. A man who is telling you what he privately believes to be true does not need to.

"Demi," he said. "Did he ever talk about faces?"

And Demi Louw, who had been laughed at by a nation, said, "Oh, he talked about *nothing else.*"

She got out her phone and showed him a voice note, thirty-one seconds, sent to her at 11:40 on a Tuesday night, which she had kept

because at the time it was the most romantic thing anyone had ever sent her and which she now could not delete for reasons she had stopped trying to explain to people.

A man's voice, low, amused, unhurried. Educated Afrikaans-English, Boland vowels sanded almost smooth.

“— no, but that’s my point, you’re not listening. Everybody thinks beauty is a matter of taste, and it isn’t, it’s a matter of arithmetic, and the arithmetic is public. The Greeks published it. Your face is about two millimetres from something people would stop in the street for, and nobody will ever tell you, and you will never know, and that’s — no, I’m not being weird, Demi, I’m being sad about it. There should be a — someone should be able to just — anyway. Sleep well.”

The traffic went by. The sea sat in its grey strip between two buildings.

“He told you,” Loots said quietly.

“Ja.”

“Two millimetres.”

“Two millimetres,” said Demi Louw, and put two fingers against her own mouth, which was, everyone agreed, extraordinary, and which had cost her a studio, a mother, and the ability to be believed.

Loots asked for the file of photographs and the phone number and the voice note, and got all three; he asked whether she would look at pictures if he brought them, and she said yes; he asked, finally, standing at the top of the stairs with the lever-arch file under his arm, the question he had not planned.

“Do you want it undone?”

Demi thought about it for a long time. It was, she said later, the only time anyone in fourteen weeks had asked her what she wanted.

“No,” she said. “That’s what makes me want to be sick, Captain. He was right. I look at myself and I’m —” Her jaw went. “He was *right*, and I never said he could, and now I have to live in it. Both of those. Every day, both.”

Loots drove back over the Neck with the file on the passenger seat and his hands at ten and two, and he did not go home. He stopped at the Engen in Sea Point and sat in the forecourt and phoned Elmarie, who was surprised to hear from him and immediately wary; he asked her for Ilse's res number, which she gave him; he phoned it and it rang out; and then he sat in the car for a while with his thumb on the screen, next to a shop selling flowers and gas and biltong at half past six in the evening.

What he wanted, and this had not happened in eighteen months either, was a drink — not the sludge in the duplex at the far end of the table, but the whole architecture of it, the ice, the second one, the third, the blessed shutting-off of the room.

Because he had spent eighteen months believing he was the only man he'd ever met who had done a monstrous thing while entirely convinced, in the moment, that he was correcting something.

And now there were two of them.

He started the car. He drove home the long way, past the sea. He poured nothing, and slept badly, and at 4:40 he got up and taped a sixth row onto the sheet on the back of his front door, and under *ESKALASIE*, in the column he had left empty for nine days, he finally wrote:

Hy vat nie meer weg nie. Hy sit by.

He isn't taking away any more. He's adding.

Nine — Stocktake

The trouble with Anri Fourie is that she cannot be flattered, cannot be hurried, does not want anything from me, and counts everything twice.

I have run a private census of the human beings I have known and she is the fourth such person and the only one under sixty. The others were: a farm foreman of my grandfather's; a nursing sister at the Paarl practice where I did second-year rotations; and my mother, who died of an unglamorous cancer when I was twenty-two and who, in the last month, kept asking me questions I had not prepared for. Four people, in twenty-nine years, on whom the instrument does not work.

It is not that they see through me. Nobody sees through me. It is that they are not looking at the surface I am maintaining. It's like performing for a man who is watching a different stage.

The month-end count is on the first Thursday, and on the first Thursday of April, Anri comes to the count with a printout.

I know it is a printout before I see it. I know it from the way she is standing in the stores when I arrive — square on to the shelves, clipboard down at her side instead of hooked on her arm, her weight on both feet — the posture of a person who has decided something and slept on it and not changed her mind.

“Môre,” she says.

“Môre. You've been busy.”

She hands it over without ceremony. Three months of ketamine and midazolam draws for the small-animal theatre, printed from the workbook — *my* workbook — with a column added on the right in her

handwriting: the theoretical minimum for each procedure on the list, calculated from the anaesthetic record. Every row is fine. Nine rows are more than fine; nine rows are *slightly* fine, in a way that a person who was not looking would never see.

Nine rows, out of four hundred and six. She has found nine of my fourteen.

I feel — I want to be exact — a rush of something warm and entirely unfamiliar, and it takes me a full second to identify it as *delight*.

“Where’d you get the theoretical minimums?” I ask.

“Calculated them.”

“From the anaesthetic records? Anri, that’s forty hours.”

“Thirty-one.” She takes back the printout, squares it on the clipboard. “You said bring it to the audit committee. I’m not going to the audit committee with a feeling.”

And this is the moment, standing between the drug fridge and the shelf of expired suture, that I understand what I am actually dealing with — not a colleague with a bee in her bonnet but a person who took a throwaway line I gave her in February purely to be agreeable, and spent thirty-one hours of her own life on it, because I said I would second it.

I have been managed by experts. I have never before been *held to a promise*.

Let me tell you how a professional handles this, because everything you think you know about it is wrong.

An amateur denies. An amateur explains. An amateur produces, on the spot, a plausible alternative account of the nine rows, and the plausible alternative account is the rope. Every man I have ever watched get caught — the vet in Worcester who was selling ketamine into Cape Town, the lecturer who fabricated the culture results, my own father, over four generations of vineyard — got caught not because someone found the thing but because he *explained* the thing before he was asked to.

What a professional does is agree.

"You're right," I say.

Anri looks up.

"Not maybe right. Right." I take the printout back, and I go down it with my thumb, and I let her watch me find the twelfth row she missed, and I circle it in pencil, and I say, "Here's another one. And I think if you do the same thing to the large-animal book you'll find three or four more, because Prof still records his own bovine draws by hand on a Friday afternoon and Prof is seventy-one."

She is quiet for a moment.

"You knew," she says. Not accusing. Establishing.

"I knew the assumption was soft. That's why the assumption exists — it's the joint in the system where reality doesn't fit the spreadsheet, and I've been treating it as a joint. You're saying treat it as a *hole*." I hand it back. "You're right. It's a hole. I'll take it to committee with you. I'll bring the workbook. Put it in your name."

"It's your workbook."

"It's your thirty-one hours."

And there it is: the smallest possible movement in the level surface of Anri Fourie's face. Not gratitude — she is not a woman with any use for that transaction — but the recognition of something being handled correctly, which is the only currency she trades in.

We count. It takes ninety minutes. She counts left-handed, twice, initials in green, and near the end she says, apropos of nothing, "You're not going to Krige's thing tomorrow?"

"I'm going. I'm just not staying."

"Mm." Then: "Bring your own if you're driving over the pass at night. There's always someone topping up the glasses at that house."

"You worry about me, Fourie."

"I worry about the second-years who lift with you on Tuesdays," she says, "and you're the only one who can close." She hangs the clipboard on its nail. "Ag, and no. I don't worry about you. You're the most careful person I've ever met."

That night I go home and do the arithmetic that matters.

Nine of fourteen. In three months. From a printout and a calculator and thirty-one hours, by one final-year student with no suspicion in her head at all — because that is the point I must not lose sight of: Anri does not suspect me of anything. She suspects the *assumption*. She is a person who cannot walk past a soft joint in a system without pressing it, in exactly the way I cannot walk past two millimetres of upper vermilion.

If I fight her, the joint becomes a hole with my name written next to it. If I help her close it, the system tightens by a factor of — I do it properly, on paper — about three and a half, and my usable margin drops to something like a quarter of what it was, and every future draw has to be defended against a tolerance calculated by the one person in the building who does the work twice.

Any reasonable man would find this a catastrophe.

I sit at the desk with the ledger open and the letter under it and I find that what I feel is not fear at all. It is something like the feeling of finally playing against someone who can play.

Because here is the truth of my last eleven years, and I have not written it down before: it has been easy. Not the surgery — the surgery is hard and I love that it is hard. Everything else. The women, the doors, the keys, the ledgers, the professor's fondness, the whole apparatus of my life, has been like playing chess against people who do not know the bishop moves diagonally. There has been nobody. Not one. Not a colleague, not a lecturer, not a woman, not a policeman, not once in four hundred and some procedures. I have been the only adult in an empty building for over a decade, and I have told myself the emptiness was proof of my quality, and it is not; the emptiness is just emptiness, and it is one of the two reasons I have started adding, and the other reason is Demi Louw's mouth.

So: the count tightens. Good. Let it tighten. I will help her tighten it, publicly, with my name on the committee minute, and I will find another way, because there is always another way; the world is made of soft joints and I have only ever needed one.

But I write two lines in the ledger that night, on the left-hand page where I keep the things that are not measurements.

A. F. — 11/14. Thirty-one hours. Left-handed. Counts twice.

And underneath, in the same steady column hand I have used since second year, the sentence that will look, later, to a man reading it under a lamp in an evidence room, like the beginning of everything:

The only one who might.

Ten — The Impossible Excision

Dr Priya Naidoo had been carrying the thing around for eleven months by the time a policeman finally phoned her about it, and her first reaction to the call was not relief. It was suspicion, because in her experience the only people who ever wanted to talk about that case were journalists, and journalists wanted the version with the word *ghost* in it.

“You’re a dermatologist,” Loots said, on the phone, in a tone she would later describe to her husband as *a man reading a label very carefully*.

“For twenty-two years.”

“Doctor, I’ve got a question that’s going to sound stupid, and I’d like you to take it seriously for about ninety seconds before you decide.”

“Everyone’s questions sound stupid. Ask.”

“If I showed you a scar,” said Loots, “could you tell me who made it?”

There was a pause on the line of a length he had learned, over twenty-six years, to read exactly.

“Captain,” said Priya Naidoo, “where are you, and how soon can you get here?”

Her rooms were on the second floor of a building on Regent Road with a lift that didn’t work and a waiting room full of very good magazines. She cleared a Wednesday afternoon, which she had not done

for anyone since her mother's funeral, and she put a lever-arch file on the desk that was, Loots noted, a twin of Demi Louw's.

"March last year," she said. "A patient — I'll call her Patient A until you tell me you've got the paper for a name."

"Theron," said Loots. "Margaux."

Naidoo sat back. "You already have her."

"She's the reason I'm here. Tell me anyway. Tell me like I don't know."

So she told him. A thirty-something woman, no dermatological history worth the name, in for a routine mole map because her medical aid had a wellness benefit and her mother had had a melanoma. Naidoo does the full body, four minutes with a dermatoscope, and comes to the face, and stops.

"There's a lesion excision above the left orbit. Old — well healed, three, four months. Beautiful work. Genuinely beautiful; you don't see closure like that in the public sector and you don't often see it in the private. So I say, well done, whoever did that, who was it. Because I'm nosy, and because if there's a plastics man in this city doing work like that I want his number for my own patients." Naidoo turned a page. "And she says: nobody did it."

"And you said?"

"I said what you'd say. Are you on anything, do you have any memory issues, are we perhaps talking about a procedure under sedation you've forgotten, did somebody do it while you were out for something else. And she got very quiet and very polite, which I have learned is what it looks like when a patient decides you're not safe." Naidoo's mouth tightened. "I lost her. She went home and I wrote *pt reports no recall of procedure* in the notes and moved on, because I had nine more patients and a septic toe."

"But you didn't move on."

"No," she said. "Because of the suture."

She had photographs — dermatoscopic, high resolution, taken at the time out of pure professional acquisitiveness — and she put them up on the wall screen one after another while Loots sat with his hands

on his knees, and she talked, and for the first time in four months the case stopped being a smell and became a set of facts a court could hold.

“This is a scar from a fusiform excision, which is bog standard. This —” a magnified section, a pale line — is the surface. There’s almost nothing to see, which is the point. But it’s what’s *underneath* that made me keep the file.”

She brought up an ultrasound. High-frequency dermal, 50 MHz, done on a second patient eleven months later, and Loots had to be led through it like a child, and did not mind.

“Deep layer,” Naidoo said. “The buried part. Now — a scar is mostly made by tension. Your surface stitches don’t hold the skin together, they just line it up; the deep layer takes the load, and how you lay that deep layer decides what the scar looks like in a year. Every surgeon has a habit. Interrupted buried dermal, that’s the standard here — little separate stitches, knot down. What’s in this woman is not that. It’s a continuous inverted pattern, running, with the bites laid at an angle and a spacing I have literally never seen in a human being.”

“Meaning what? He’s foreign?”

“That’s what I thought first. I sent the images, anonymised, to a plastics professor at Wits, and to a man I trained with who’s in Melbourne now, and to a woman in Rotterdam. Two of them said, no idea. The one in Melbourne said —” she found the email and read it out “— *this looks like a pattern from a completely different surgical tradition. Are you sure your patient wasn’t operated on by a vet?* And then a smiley face, because he was joking.”

The room was quiet. Outside, the traffic on Regent Road did what it always does.

“He was joking,” Naidoo said again.

Loots had gone very still, in the way that people who had worked with him used to watch for.

“Doctor,” he said. “Say the rest.”

“I ordered a textbook.” She pulled it out from under the desk, a fat blue thing with a cow on the cover: *Large Animal Surgery — Principles and Techniques*, fourth edition, with about forty coloured tabs

sticking out of it. “Two hundred and eighty rand, second-hand, from a student in Onderstepoort. It’s in there, Captain. Chapter eleven. It’s a standard closure for the abdominal wall of production animals, where the patient is going to be walking around in a kraal on the second day and the wound has to hold against a thousand kilos of gut. There is no reason on God’s earth for it to exist in the eyebrow of a woman in Camps Bay.”

She put the book down on the desk between them, tabs out, like a weapon being surrendered.

“And the material,” she said. “That’s the other thing. The suture. I took a sample from the second patient’s revision — polyglecaprone, but a size and a coating that isn’t stocked by any of the three aesthetic suppliers in this province. I phoned them all. It’s a veterinary line. It’s not illegal, it’s not exotic, it’s just — it’s what you’d have in your hand if your hands lived in an animal theatre.”

Loots looked at the blue book for a long moment.

“Doctor, why didn’t you take this anywhere?”

Priya Naidoo laughed, one syllable, without any humour in it at all.

“I did,” she said. “In August I phoned the police station in Sea Point and a very nice young man told me that if my patient wanted to lay a charge my patient could come in. In September I wrote to the HPCSA, because my working theory then was that it was a doctor — a struck-off man, someone with a grudge — and they wrote back in fourteen weeks to say there was no registered practitioner to investigate. In October I mentioned it at a congress in Durban, in a corridor, to three colleagues, and one of them called me *the ghost surgeon lady* for the rest of the weekend.” She squared the file. “So no. I stopped taking it anywhere. I kept it, and I’ve been waiting eleven months for somebody to phone me, and you’re the first person who has, and I need you to understand that in that eleven months I have had two more.”

Loots’s pen stopped.

“Two more what?”

“Two more patients,” said Naidoo, “with work in them nobody did.”

He came out onto Regent Road at half past five with the lever-arch file, the blue textbook, and a hand-written list of two names and two dates, and stood on the pavement in the wind for a while, doing what he did.

The Service does not train you for the moment when a case turns from a suspicion into a man, and there is no word for it in the manuals, but every good detective has a private one. Loots's was his grandfather's, from the farm at Riversdal: *die spoor vat*. The track takes. You are following nothing, nothing, nothing, and then the ground gives you a direction, and from that moment on the animal is no longer a rumour; it is a thing with a size and a weight that walked here and put its foot exactly there.

He got into the car and did not start it. He wrote in the notebook, in Afrikaans:

Veearts. Of veeartsstudent.

A vet. Or a vet student.

Then, underneath, three lines, because the profile that would be read in September was assembling itself in his chest whether he liked it or not:

Hy's opgelei — maar nie in mense nie. Iemand het hom weggewys. Hy hou van die werk meer as die vrou. En hy dink hy's beter as die manne wat wel die papier het.

He is trained — but not on people. Somebody turned him away. He loves the work more than he wants the woman. And he thinks he is better than the men who got the paper.

Loots looked at those three lines for a long time in the failing light. Then he took out his phone and called Delpont, and when she answered he said, without preliminaries, "Kolonel, I need Onderstepoort. And I need the new place in Stellenbosch."

"Gidi," said Delpont, in the voice of a woman watching a rope run out, "what's in Stellenbosch?"

"About two hundred people," said Loots, "who can close a wound better than your doctor can, and one of them isn't a vet at all. He's a surgeon who got sent to the wrong faculty."

Eleven — The Chapel

The cellar was dug into the hill in 1798 by people whose names are not in any record I have been able to find, and I think about that more than is useful.

Two hundred and twenty-eight years of cold. That is what you feel on the steps — not damp, not the ordinary chill of a room without sun, but a temperature that has been sitting in this hillside since before the Cape had a British governor, laid down by hands that hacked it out of the shale with iron tools and no drawings, so that a Vermeulen who was not yet a Vermeulen could keep his wine at a stable thirteen degrees. The walls are a metre thick where the barrel vault springs. My great-great-grandfather ran a hosepipe down here in 1911 and the mark of it is still on the wall like a tideline. Frik put in the steel door and the three-phase board in 1994 and then lost interest, as our family loses interest, and went to Hermanus to fish.

I have been coming down these steps since I was six years old. And for twenty-three of those years the room behind the steel door was a room with things in it — a table, a lamp, a trolley, a sterilizer that I bought at an auction of a closed practice in Malmesbury for nineteen thousand rand and rebuilt myself. A workshop. A very good workshop, in a very good hiding place, but a workshop, in the way a garage with a lift in it is a workshop.

That is over now, and I want to set down honestly when it changed, because I have found that men in my position are always assumed to have been building the cathedral from the start, and I was not. I was fixing scratches in a garage.

It changed the night I sat back from Demi Louw's mouth and heard the orchestra find its A.

There is a phase in this work that nobody who has not done it can imagine, and it is not the cutting. It is the *procurement*, and it is where every clever amateur in the history of the world has hanged himself.

I will not tell you what I bought or where, and you should not want me to; that particular appetite — the reader who wants the shopping list so that the story can be a manual — is the same appetite I am supposed to be the monster for. What I will tell you is the shape of the problem, because the shape is the interesting part, and because the shape is the reason I am careful and the men who get caught are not.

Everything I need falls into three classes. There are things any citizen may buy: linen, light, stainless, steam. There are things a veterinary practice may buy, and a final-year student with a supervisor's account and eleven years of impeccable stock-keeping is, for these purposes, a veterinary practice. And then there is the third class — the things that exist only in human medicine, made by three companies in the world, sold through two distributors in this country, tracked by lot number from factory to theatre, and unobtainable by anyone whose name is not on a register I was refused entry to eleven years ago by one mark in a language paper.

That third class is the entire architecture of my problem. It is also, more than the doctrine, more than the mathematics, the reason for everything that happened afterwards, and I want that understood: a man cannot become what he is capable of becoming if the world will not sell him the parts.

So one solves it. One solves it slowly, over eleven months, in a manner I decline to describe, involving the ordinary porousness of a supply chain that runs from Johannesburg to Lagos to Nairobi, and the fact that in this country there are men who will sell anything to anyone and men who will sell nothing to a stranger, and the entire craft is learning which is which without ever once being memorable to either.

And then one Saturday in autumn you carry the last crate down the steps and stand in the doorway and the room is no longer a workshop.

It is white now. That is the first thing anyone would notice, if anyone ever came: the vault is white to the springing line, four coats, epoxy over primer over two hundred and twenty-eight years of slate dust, and the floor is poured resin coved at the walls so there is no join anywhere for anything to gather in. There is a scrub sink with elbow taps. There is an autoclave with a validation log I keep in the same column hand as the ledger, because a sterilizer that is not validated is a rumour, and I have never in my life relied on a rumour. There is a filtration unit in the old ventilation shaft that cost more than my bakkie and moves the air of that room seventeen times an hour, so that the cellar which held the family's Chenin at thirteen degrees now holds a cleaner atmosphere than the theatre I gownned up in on Tuesday. There are two anaesthetic monitors, one primary, one redundant, because I am not a cowboy and I have watched what happens on a table when a man relies on one of anything.

And there is the table, in the middle, under the light.

The light is the thing I would show you if I could show you one thing. A proper theatre lamp, five heads, shadowless — bought broken, rebuilt across four months with a soldering iron and a service manual in German I worked through with a dictionary — and when you switch it on in a room with a metre of hillside overhead, the darkness does not retreat, it is *deleted*, and what is left is a circle of daylight about the size of a person, floating in a cold black nowhere.

I sat on the stool the first night it worked and looked at that circle for an hour without any thought in my head at all, which has happened to me perhaps four times in my life.

You will want to know what I call the room. I call it the cellar, because I am not a fool and one guards one's language the way one guards one's keys. But the word that arrives when I am tired, coming down the steps in the small hours with the valley asleep above me and the light waiting, is the word my mother's family used for the little Dutch Reformed church at Pniel where the farm's people were christened: die kapel.

The chapel. Ja. I know exactly how that sounds. I have read the same books you have.

But consider what a chapel actually is, before the word got sticky: a small stone room, kept cold and clean, dug into a hillside or built at

the edge of a farm, where a thing is done to a person's body in front of witnesses in order to change what that person will be for the rest of their life. Water on a head. Bread in a mouth. Hands. That is the entire technology of the sacrament and it has not changed in two thousand years, and nobody in that building ever asked the infant for consent, and the infant grew up and was grateful, and the whole of Western civilisation was built on people being permanently altered, in a cold room, while they were too small to object.

I am not making a joke. I have never made a joke about this.

Anri asks me, in the stores on the Thursday, why I look tired, and I tell her the truth, which is that I have been rewiring an old building, and she says, "The farm?", and I say, "The cellar," and she says, "Frik still not selling?", and I say, "Frik's fishing," and she makes the small noise she makes at all human folly and goes back to counting.

That is the entire exchange. It has stayed with me for months. Because standing in that room with her, with the shelves and the green initials and the ordinary Thursday, I felt for the first time in my life the thing I imagine ordinary men feel constantly and call a conscience, except that it was not moral in any way I could locate. It was structural. It was the feeling of a man who has been living in two rooms with a wall between them, and who notices, one Thursday, that the wall is load-bearing, and is not as thick as he had assumed.

I went down to the chapel that night and did nothing at all. I sat on the stool under the deleted darkness with a notebook and I drew, for the first time, a plan that was not a repair.

Because the mouth was two millimetres and the mouth changed a woman's standing in the world, and the mouth was *twenty minutes*, and everything I have described in this chapter — the vault, the filtration, the redundant monitor, the eleven months of procurement, the light — exists for one reason, which is that the human body has other margins, larger and deeper and more load-bearing than a lip, and they take four hours instead of twenty minutes, and they cannot be done in a garage.

Two millimetres was the apprentice piece. I have built the room now.

Above me, that night, the valley did what it does: the frogs in the dam,

a jackal somewhere on the Simonsberg side, the neighbour's dogs answering each other across two farms. Two hundred and twenty-eight years of other people's cold, and a circle of daylight the size of a person, waiting in the middle of it.

I switched off the lamp, and locked the steel door, and went up the steps into the ordinary night, and the last thing I thought before the door of the house closed behind me was not about a woman at all.

It was: I should have a second aspirator. Never rely on one of anything.

Twelve — The Sculptor

The story broke on a Sunday, in a lifestyle supplement, under the headline THE MIDNIGHT SCULPTOR, next to a photograph of a woman's mouth that was not any of the victims' mouths but a stock image bought for nine dollars.

Loots read it standing up in a Woolworths in Panorama with the milk in his other hand.

It was two thousand words long and it was not, in the technical sense, wrong. It had the Camps Bay woman (unnamed), the Sea Point yoga instructor (unnamed, but there were only so many yoga instructors in Sea Point and by Tuesday her studio's Instagram had nineteen thousand new followers and one review that said *does the ghost do necks*), and a quote from a Green Point aesthetic practitioner who said, and Loots read this sentence four times in the dairy aisle, "*Look, obviously it's a crime, but from a purely technical standpoint the work I've seen is exquisite. Whoever this is, they're better than most people I trained with.*"

There was a paragraph beginning *Whatever else he is, he appears to have excellent taste.*

There was a pull-quote, in forty-point type, that read: *He takes nothing. He leaves you better.*

There was no mention of Nadia Prinsloo, because in April Nadia Prinsloo was still a healthy thirty-four-year-old estate agent in Bantry Bay with a full range of facial expression.

Loots bought the milk. In the car park he sat with the paper on the steering wheel and read the last three paragraphs again, and then he folded it very carefully into quarters, and then he put his fist into

it, once, hard, so that the paper burst against the wheel, and then he sat there breathing with his hands on his knees for about a minute and a half.

A hundred and ninety seconds, he thought. That's how long you can be reasonable for.

He unfolded the paper, smoothed it out on the passenger seat, and drove to the office.

The taskforce meeting was on the Wednesday, in the Provincial building, in the room with the long table where he had once run Tuesday parades for nineteen detectives, and Loots knew exactly what it was going to be from the seating.

He was not at the head of the table. He was two-thirds down, next to the projector cable, in the chair you sit in when your role in a meeting is to be available.

Brigadier Steenkamp chaired it. There were fourteen people in the room, of whom nine had been sent because the story had run in a Sunday paper and a DA member of the provincial legislature had said the words *public confidence* on television, and of those nine, Loots reckoned, four were there to make sure nothing happened that could later be described as an overreaction to a case in which nobody had been robbed, injured, or killed.

“Right,” said Steenkamp. “Captain Loots has been carrying this. Gideon — briefly, please. There’s a lot on.”

Briefly.

He did it in eight minutes. He did it well; he had been doing this since before half the room joined the Service, and he did it without the sarcasm sitting in the back of his throat like a coin. Nine complainants now, of whom six formal. Method consistent across two and a half years. Venue profile, catchment, month-end pattern, the water and the two tablets. The escalation from removal to addition, dated to March. And then the forensic spine: Dr Naidoo, the buried continuous inverted pattern, the veterinary suture line, the Melbourne professor’s joke.

“So he’s a vet,” said a colonel from Provincial Crime Intelligence.

“Or a student, or someone struck off, or someone who did three years and dropped out. There’s Onderstepoort, there’s the new faculty at Stellenbosch, there’s about three thousand registered vets in this province and I don’t need all of them. I need the ones with access to a theatre, a sterilizer and a schedule that leaves them free on weeknights on the Atlantic seaboard, and I need the ones who were rejected from medicine, because —”

“Because?” said Steenkamp.

“Because he told one of them he was a surgeon,” said Loots. “Flat. And when the man at the table corrected him — *ja but a vet* — he let it go and smiled. Brigadier, a liar argues. He wasn’t lying. He was being *modest*.”

There was a silence in the room of a texture Loots recognised: the sound of fourteen people deciding, individually, whether they were the kind of person who found that impressive or embarrassing.

“What do you need?” said Steenkamp.

“Six things.” He put them on the table one at a time, and they were, on any objective reading, cheap: a subject-matter subpoena to two faculties for enrolment and disciplinary records; access to the veterinary supply distributors’ order data; toxicology re-testing on the two complainants inside the window; a public appeal, worded by him; a dedicated number; and one warrant officer, full time.

He got three of the six. No public appeal — “the last thing we do is give a man like this a national platform, Captain, you’ve seen what the Sunday paper did.” No supply data without a specific target. No toxicology, because of budget, actually literally because of budget, a line item, in the year of our Lord.

And he got the warrant officer.

“Nkosi,” said Steenkamp. “Zintle. She’s coming across from FCS in Bellville.”

“I know her work,” said Loots, and did: she had done the file on the Belhar creche matter, and it was the most complete file he had read in four years.

“She’s good,” said Steenkamp, in the tone of a man laying something down carefully. “She’s also — Gideon, I’ll say this in front of everyone,

so nobody has to say it in the corridor. She's not there to help you carry boxes. Colonel Delport and I agreed that this docket has a full-time second detective on it, and that the second detective files her own weekly note. Directly."

Babysitter, said every face in the room, silently, politely.

"Ja, Brigadier," said Loots.

She was waiting at his desk on the Thursday morning at ten past seven with two coffees, one of which she gave him, and a printout of his own eleven-page profile with about sixty annotations in the margins.

Warrant Officer Zintle Nkosi was thirty-six, wore a jacket that fitted properly, and had the specific calm of a person who has already had the difficult conversation in her head and is now waiting to see which version she'll need.

"Captain."

"Warrant."

"I read your profile last night." She sat down without being asked, which he approved of. "Three questions, and then we can do the part where you tell me you don't need a minder and I tell you I don't care."

Loots put his bag down slowly. "Ask."

"One. You've got 'he thinks he's helping' as your organising principle. Everything hangs off that. If you're wrong, we're a year down the wrong road."

"I'm not wrong."

"That's not an answer, it's a temperature." She didn't look up from the page. "Two. You've built the profile off six women and three second-hand accounts. Have you spoken to the women about *him*, or about what he did? Because your notes are full of the surgery and thin on the man. Someone spent two months in Demi Louw's life. That's a lot of hours to leave out of a profile."

Loots opened his mouth and closed it.

“Three.” Now she did look up. “Why is there nothing in here about what happens when he can’t do it any more?”

“Meaning?”

“He’s escalating. You’ve said it four times in eleven pages. Escalation means the procedures get bigger, longer, riskier — and it means that at some point one of them goes wrong on the table, and he’s got a woman in a room who is not going to wake up right.” Nkosi laid the profile down flat. “Your whole document is about how he catches women. There’s not one line about what he does the first time he ruins one. And Captain — that’s the day this case starts, and it’s coming, and I’d like us to have thought about it before it gets here rather than after.”

The office made its ordinary morning noise around them: a printer, someone’s phone, the kettle.

Loots picked up the coffee she’d brought him and held it in both hands and looked at this woman who had been sent to file weekly notes on him.

“You’re right,” he said.

Nkosi waited, visibly braced for the rest of the sentence, and the rest of the sentence did not come.

“That’s it?” she said.

“You’re right and I’ll fix it. What did you think I was going to do, argue?”

“Honestly, Captain,” said Nkosi, “I read your file too. I thought you’d throw the coffee.”

Loots looked at the cup, and something happened at the side of his mouth that had not happened in front of another police officer in a year and a half.

“Ja,” he said. “Well. That’s a reasonable read of the paperwork.”

He pulled out the chair beside his desk with his foot, which was as close as he came to a welcome, and pushed the blue textbook with the cow on it across the desk towards her.

“Chapter eleven,” he said. “Start there. And Nkosi — the thing you said about the day one of them doesn’t wake up right.”

“Ja?”

“Write it in your weekly note. Word for word, and put the date on it.” He was already reaching for the phone. “Because when it happens, they’re going to want to know when somebody first said it out loud in this building, and I want the answer to be you, in writing, in April.”

PART III — THE DOCTRINE

“Men are so simple that he who deceives will always find someone who lets himself be deceived.” — Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince*

Thirteen — The Creed

I was eleven years old the first time I understood that the world had made an error and that nobody was going to correct it.

The farm's people lived at the bottom of the werf in four cottages with a shared tap, and the woman who ran the kitchen was called Sarah Titus, and her daughter Elmien was my age exactly — three days between us — and for the first eleven years of my life we were, in the entirely unexamined way of farm children, a single organism with two bodies. We fished the dam. We stole the first grapes and were sick. She could climb better than me and I could swim better than her and neither of us had any theory about any of it.

Then there was a wedding — a cousin, in the Boland Anglican church at Pniel, four hundred people — and I stood at the back with my collar cutting my neck and watched Elmien's mother come in to help serve, and Elmien with her, in a borrowed dress, eleven years old, at the edge of a room full of my family.

And I watched, over the course of about forty minutes, my entire extended family fail to see her.

Not cruelty. That is the thing I need said exactly, because cruelty would have been *easier*, cruelty is a signal, cruelty tells a child where the walls are. Nobody was cruel. My aunts were warm to Sarah. My uncle knew Elmien's name and used it. And every single one of them looked directly at the most extraordinary face in that building — and I mean that as a measurement, I have since taken the measurement, I know precisely what I am claiming — and their eyes went over her the way your eye goes over a chair.

Meanwhile, on the other side of the room, my cousin Marlien, aged

nineteen, was being told she was beautiful, four times an hour, by everyone.

And I stood at the back with my collar cutting my neck and I did the sum, because I have always done the sum. Marlien's face against Elmien's face: the ratio of nose-base to lip-centre against lip-centre to chin; the mandibular angle; the interpupillary against the bizygomatic; the malar projection that photographers spend careers chasing and that Elmien Titus had been issued at birth for free. It was not close. It has never once been close, in thirty years of measuring.

The whole room had agreed, unanimously and without discussion, that the less beautiful woman was the beautiful one. Four hundred educated people, in a building put up for the worship of truth, all wrong, all comfortable, all certain.

That was the day I understood that the eye can be trained to lie, and that ours had been.

I have spent eighteen years since then reading about it, and there is no mystery, and it is not even controversial except in the specific rooms where it would cost money to admit it.

Go and look at what our species actually makes when it makes an image of a human being on purpose. Go to the Iziko and look at the Benin bronzes — the ones our great-grandfathers took at gun-point and put behind glass — and look at the malar architecture, the eye spacing, the proportion of the lip. Go to the Egyptian galleries. Look at the Ife heads out of Nigeria, which are the most sophisticated sculptural representations of the human face made anywhere on earth before the fifteenth century and which are so proportionally exact that when they were first shown in Europe the scholars decided a Greek must have made them, because they could not accommodate the alternative.

The face our species carved when it wanted to carve *perfection* is not the face on the cover of the magazines in the Woolworths in Sea Point. It is not within four centimetres of that face. The archives of human art are unambiguous, the anthropometric literature is unambiguous, and the only people who find this a difficult sentence are people who have something at stake in it.

African beauty is the human template. Everything else on this planet is a variation written under a different sun, and some of the variations are lovely and one of them, mine, is a thin pale drift a long way from home — and the great obscenity of the last four hundred years is not merely that we conquered the people who kept the template. It is that we then persuaded the entire world, including them, to file it down.

The skin-lighteners on the shelf at the Shoprite in Kayamandi. The women in my own lecture theatre who will not wear their own hair. Eleven billion dollars a year, globally, to make people less like the sculpture that half the museums of Europe are still holding.

I have never touched a Black woman's face. Not once, in four hundred and some procedures, and I never will. There is nothing to correct and I would not have the arrogance. My work is exclusively, deliberately, doctrinally performed on my own people: on the pale, moneyed, cut-and-filled women of that coastline — the ones who fly to Turkey for a jaw, who pay a man in Sandton nine thousand rand a syringe to chase a proportion their own great-grandmothers took from a continent they refused to look at. I am not stealing from anyone. I am doing, for free, at three in the morning, in a cold room, what they are already paying strangers to do badly.

And I am doing it *toward the template*, instead of away from it, which is the only difference between me and the practice on Kloof Street with the reviews and the parking.

That is the creed. I have never said it out loud to another human being. I am aware of how it will read in a newspaper. I am not aware of any part of it that is false.

Bianca Steyn is thirty, sells wellness on the internet, has a face that runs one point five two where the peak is one point six one, and burns.

That is the detail that decided her. Not the face — the burning. I watched her at a table in Clifton in November scanning the awning line the way a lizard scans for shade, hunting the one seat where the sun would not reach her, and I watched a woman spend an entire lunch in physical anxiety about a star, and I thought: *this is a species that has been moved to the wrong latitude and has decided*

the latitude is correct.

Two hundred generations out of Africa and we are still, biologically, tourists here. We come to a coastline with an ultraviolet index that pushes fourteen in January, and we peel, and we blister, and we grow the melanomas Dr Naidoo cuts out for a living, and then we lie on the sand to obtain, painfully and temporarily and with a permanent bill in DNA damage, four shades of the thing we spent four centuries despising in the people who actually live here.

You cannot make this up. Nobody could make this up.

So: pigment.

I will describe none of it. I have described none of my methods and I am not going to begin with this one, because this is the procedure that would be lifted, and I have no interest in adding to the supply of men in rented rooms doing to women what I do properly. What I will say is that I did not go near her face — the face was not the point, and the face is where a change is noticed and the change I intended was to be lived in, not looked at. Two sessions, seven weeks apart, on the dorsal surfaces where a woman looks first for the confirmation of a summer. It is not a dye. It is not a tattoo. It is an instruction, and the instruction is one her own cells knew how to follow.

She noticed in the third week and told forty thousand people it was a new supplement. She has, at the time I write this, sold ninety thousand units of it.

I would like to say I found that funny. I found it clarifying. I had given a woman four shades of the only genuine protection our species ever evolved against the sun she is terrified of, and she metabolised it, within twenty-one days, into a product.

And still: none of this is the part I cannot defend.

I can defend the doctrine to any court in this land — not legally, obviously, but intellectually, which is the only jurisdiction I have ever really lived in. I know what the doctrine is *for*, and so, I suspect, do you: a man who was refused at one door has built a cathedral of justification with the door as its cornerstone, and if you want to make me small you may say that all of this — the Ife heads, the museums, the

anthropometry, eighteen years of reading — is one boy at the back of a church at Pniel, with his collar cutting his neck, discovering that the world does not see correctly and deciding that he would therefore be the one who sees.

Say it. It may even be true. A thing can be motivated and correct.

Here is the part I cannot defend, and I set it down because this is the only honest document that will exist about me:

Elmien Titus is a district nurse in Wellington now. She has three children. We have not spoken in nineteen years. And in eleven years of this work — through four hundred procedures, through the ledger, through the mask and the calipers and the light in the chapel — I have never once been able to answer the question that any competent psychologist would ask me in the first fifteen minutes.

If the template is perfect and must never be altered. And if my work is dedicated, doctrinally, to the correction of my own people toward it.

Then why is the number I measure everything against — the number in the ledger, the number on the mask, the number I have been chasing since I was eleven years old —

the face of a girl I stopped speaking to when we were children, because a room full of my family looked straight through her, and I did not say a word.

Fourteen — What Worship Costs

The pigment case came to them sideways, the way the good ones do, through a woman who had not reported anything and did not think anything had happened to her.

Nkosi found it. She had built, in six weeks, the thing Loots had not built in four months: a search that did not rely on complaints. Complaints were the problem — the whole architecture of the man was designed to produce women who did not know they were victims — so Nkosi went at it from the other end. She wrote a scraper (she did this herself, on a laptop, at her kitchen table, which Loots would mention to Delport twice) that trawled the Cape Town wellness internet for a specific grammatical shape: first-person accounts of unexplained physical improvement, posted by women, in the last thirty months, in a radius.

Two thousand two hundred hits. She read them all. Eleven were real.

And one of them, posted in March by an account with forty-one thousand followers, was a two-minute video in which a woman named Bianca Steyn, laughing, delighted, holding her forearm up to a ring light, told her audience that after eleven years of factor 50 and Irish-girl misery she had started a marine collagen and beta-carotene protocol and *look at me, you guys, I actually tan now*.

Nkosi watched it four times and then took her laptop through to Loots's desk and put it down in front of him without a word.

He watched it twice.

"That's not a tan," he said.

“No.”

“That’s not a —” He stopped. Rewound. Watched the arm again. “Warrant, what am I looking at?”

“I don’t know yet,” said Nkosi. “But I know she didn’t buy it in a bottle, and I know she’s the first one who’s happy.”

Priya Naidoo, when they brought it to her, went quiet in a way neither of them liked.

She looked at the video. She looked at the four photographs Nkosi had pulled from the woman’s own feed at four-month intervals. Then she got up and closed her office door, which she had not done for them before.

“If I’m right about what that is,” she said, “then I need you both to understand what it means, and it isn’t what you think. It doesn’t mean he’s a better criminal. It means he’s a better *scientist* than anybody you’ve been imagining, and that he did human experimentation on a sleeping woman in a shed, twice, seven weeks apart, and got a result that a laboratory with ethics approval and a budget would be pleased with.” She sat down. “That’s a different man from the one who fixes eyebrows. I’d like it on the record that I said that in May.”

“You’re the second person to say something like that to me this year,” said Loots.

“Then listen to us,” said Naidoo.

They interviewed Bianca Steyn on a Tuesday, in her flat above Clifton, with the whole blue enormity of the Atlantic in the window behind her. It was the worst interview of the case.

She did not believe them. Then she believed them, and the belief arrived in stages, like weather coming over the mountain: first, a kind of hilarity — *no, but I would have felt something, I’d have known* — then the calculating look of a woman running back through two years of an online business built on a product that did not do what she had told forty-one thousand people it did, then the moment she understood she was going to have to give the money back, then, finally, at about the thirty-minute mark, in a silence that neither detective interrupted, the thing itself.

"He was in here," she said.

"Yes," said Nkosi.

"Twice."

"We think twice, ma'am."

Bianca Steyn looked at her own forearms, front and back, turning them over, the way a person looks at hands that have done something in a dream, and then she got up and went to the bathroom and was quietly sick, and came back, and sat down, and said, in an entirely different voice: "What did he *think* he was doing?"

And Nkosi said, "That's what we're trying to find out."

And Loots said nothing at all, because he already knew, and had known since the beach-cleanup voice note, and had been carrying it around for six weeks the way you carry a stone in a shoe.

They took the long way back, over Kloof Nek, because Nkosi wanted the sea and Loots wanted the time.

"Say it," she said, halfway down.

"Say what?"

"Whatever it is you've been not saying since Bantry Bay. Captain, you had it before Naidoo opened her mouth."

Loots drove for a while.

"He thinks he's the one who sees them," he said. "That's the whole engine. He looks at a woman and he sees — he'd say *beauty*, he'd say he's the only man in the room who actually looked. And then he corrects her towards it. And the pigment thing —" He shook his head slowly. "Warrant, a man doesn't do that because he hates them. That's not a hate crime. He's got a *theory*, and the theory's about race, and I'd put my pension on which way it runs."

"Say which way."

"He thinks Black women are the standard," said Loots. "And he's making white women more like them. In their sleep. Without asking."

Nkosi was quiet for a moment. Then she laughed — one short, appalled, entirely mirthless sound — and looked out at the sea.

“Ja,” she said. “Of course he does.”

“You’re not surprised.”

“Captain, I’ve met this man about four hundred times.” She turned in the seat to face him. “Not him. *This man*. The one at the gallery opening who tells me my bone structure is a Benin bronze. The guy on the dating app whose whole profile is a lecture about how European standards are a colonial imposition, and who has never once in his life dated a woman who looks like his mother. The photographer who wants to shoot me ‘as I really am’ and turns out to mean ‘wet, and outside.’” She let a beat go past. “The compliment is the tell. Nobody who thinks of you as a person opens with a *theory* of your face.”

“But he’s on your side of the argument.”

“There is no side,” said Nkosi flatly. “That’s what you’re not hearing. He’s not on my side, he’s doing the same thing from the other end. A man who decides your body is defective and cuts it, and a man who decides your body is perfect and cuts *somebody else’s* to look like it — Captain, both of them started in the same place, which is that a woman’s body is a thing that gets decided about. Not by her.” She turned back to the window. “One of them insults you and one of them worships you and neither of them has ever once asked you a question about yourself. Elmien Titus, wherever she is —”

“Who?”

“Whoever she is,” said Nkosi. “There’s always one. Some woman he’s built the whole cathedral around who has no idea she’s in it, and who never got asked either.”

Loots drove. The city came up around them, the highway, the container cranes, the mountain going brown-gold behind.

“You want me to write that in the profile,” he said at last.

“I want you to *understand* it before you write it, because you’re going to be in a room with him one day and you’ll think you can talk to him,” said Nkosi. “And you will be able to. That’s the trap. Half the men in that taskforce would find him charming for an hour and think that

meant something. You'll find him charming for an hour and think it means you've got him."

He dropped her at Bellville and did not go home.

He drove instead to Goodwood, and parked in the street opposite a face-brick house with a carport and a Jetta under it, and sat there in the dark for a long time, which was, he was aware, the behaviour of a man in a different kind of file.

Number 41. Ryan Adonis's mother's house. Adonis was in Brandvlei doing seventeen years, and his mother, who was sixty-eight and had done nothing to anyone, had had her window broken twice by people who thought the son's sins were transferable, and Loots — this had never appeared in any tribunal document — had paid for the glass both times, anonymously, through a glazier in Parow who thought he was doing a favour for a neighbour.

He looked at the house.

He's got a theory, he'd said, that afternoon, on Kloof Nek, in the voice he used for suspects.

And then Nkosi had said the thing about the trap, and had not known — could not have known, she'd been in FCS in Bellville and had only ever seen the eleven seconds like everybody else — that Gideon Loots had spent eighteen months constructing a theory of his own. A very good one. He could deliver it in ninety seconds and had, to Elmarie, to the psychologist, to the union representative, to his own reflection at 4:40 in the morning: what Adonis had said in that cell, what Adonis had *done* in the week before that cell, what the system would and would not do about it, and therefore what had been necessary, in that room, at that moment, by his hands.

He thinks he is helping.

He had written that sentence in April about another man. He had written it in Afrikaans, first, because that was the language his conscience spoke in, and he had felt clever writing it, and had gone home and had a Klipdrift and Coke and slept better than usual.

Loots sat in the car outside number 41 Goodwood and, for the first time, put the sentence in the first person.

Ek dink ek help.

He got home at half past ten. The bottle was where he had left it, at the far end of the kitchen table, and he stood with his hands on the back of the chair and looked at it for a long moment.

Then he took it to the sink and poured it out, and stood there while it went, and it took much longer than he expected — you never think how long a bottle takes — and afterwards he rinsed the sink, because it was his mother's house's habit in his hands, and put the empty in the bin, and washed the plate that had been in the sink since Sunday.

He phoned Ilse at twenty to midnight, which is too late, and she did not answer, and this time he left a message.

"Ilse. It's Pappa. Nee, alles's reg — nothing's wrong. I just wanted to say —" a long pause on the recording, eleven seconds of a man in a kitchen "— I'm on a case. It's a good one. And there's a thing I have to work out about it, about myself, and I think you know what it is, and I'm —" Another pause. "Ek's besig om dit uit te werk. That's all. Sleep lekker, my kind."

He did not sleep. At 4:40 he got up, and made coffee, and at the kitchen table, in a notebook, he began the eleven pages again from the first line — and the first line this time was not about the suspect at all.

Fifteen — The Variance

The audit committee accepted our submission on the fourteenth of May, unanimously, in nine minutes, and the faculty officer said the words “exemplary student initiative” into the minutes, and Prof Krige put his hand on the back of my neck afterwards in the corridor like a man cuffing a favourite dog and said we were a credit to the place.

Anri’s name is first on the minute. I put it there and I did not tell her I had.

The new tolerance is 0.6 per cent. Itemised wastage. Every draw above the theoretical minimum requires a line of explanation on the anaesthetic record, countersigned, at the time — not at month-end, at the time — and the reconciliation runs weekly instead of monthly, and the workbook now generates an exception report automatically and mails it to three people, of whom I am one and Anri is another and the third is a faculty officer who will never read it and whose non-reading is worth precisely nothing to me, because Anri reads everything.

My usable margin is now approximately nil.

I did that. I want the record to show that I engineered, seconded, drafted and championed the system that closed my own supply, and that I did it in nine minutes in a committee room while a woman I like watched me do it, and that I would do it again, because the alternative was a hole in the ground with my name beside it. The Florentine again: *the wise prince, when he has the opportunity, ought with craft to foster some enmity, so that by suppressing it he may augment his greatness*. I have never found a better description of what it is to be your own auditor.

But nil is nil, and I have four hours' work planned for the winter, and four hours' work does not run on nothing.

So I go around it, and the way around it is not clever, and I want to say clearly to whoever eventually reads this: the way around is *never* clever. Clever is what gets men caught. Clever is the vet in Worcester with the second set of books. The way around is always, always boring, and it is always something that was already true.

The faculty has an outreach programme. Four days a month, a bakkie and a trailer, into the townships and the farm settlements — Kaya-mandi, Klapmuts, Pniel, out towards Wellington — sterilising dogs and cats for nothing, because a spayed dog does not have six puppies that starve. Second- and third-years do the routine work; a final-year runs the surgical list; a supervisor signs. It is the best thing this faculty does. I am not being ironic. It is genuinely the best thing we do and I have volunteered for every one of those days since second year, forty-one of them, in the rain, on Saturdays, and there is a photograph of me in the atrium holding somebody's cattle dog under a gazebo in Klapmuts.

Field lists do not reconcile against theoretical minimums. They cannot. Nobody weighs a township dog to the gram; you estimate, you draw for the estimate, you use what you use, and the record says *est. 14 kg* and the record is honest and useless. The variance lives in the field, where it has always lived, where every vet in this country knows it lives, and where no committee will ever touch it because touching it means fewer dogs.

Nine months of my requirements, spread across a year of Saturdays, drawn honestly, recorded honestly, in a system that cannot know the difference.

I am aware of what I am. I do the sterilisations. Forty-one Saturdays. The dogs are real.

On the last Thursday in May, Anri comes to the count with the exception report and one row highlighted.

It is not one of mine. That is the thing that nearly stops my heart in

the doorway of the stores, one full second of genuine physiological response, the first in eleven years: a highlighted row, and the number is not mine, and for that second I have no idea what is happening in my own life.

It is Prof Krige's. A bovine draw on a Friday afternoon in April, recorded by hand, 40 per cent over. Anri has flagged it because the system flagged it and because she flags what the system flags.

"It's arithmetic," I say, when I can see the page. "Look — he's written the dose per kilo and then multiplied by the whole herd weight instead of the animal. He's seventy-one, Anri, he does it in his head at four o'clock on a Friday."

"I know," she says. "I checked it against the other three that week. It's the same error twice."

"So it's a training note."

"It's a training note about a man who taught both of us," she says, "and if I write it up he gets an exception letter from a faculty officer who's thirty-four and has never been in a large-animal theatre, and it goes in his file in the last year of his career."

We stand there for a moment in the cold of the drug fridge.

This is the second time in four months I have watched Anri Fourie do the thing that makes her, in my private taxonomy, more interesting than every other person in this province: she is not asking me what to do. She has already decided; she is telling me, so that I can be prepared for it, because we are two signatures on the same page and she will not do a thing in our shared name that I only learn about afterwards.

"What are you going to do?" I ask anyway, because I want to hear her say it.

"I'm going to go to Prof," she says, "on Tuesday, in his office, with the four records and a calculator, and I'm going to ask him to show me how he does it, and then he'll see it himself, and then he'll change how he does it, and nothing goes in his file."

"And if he tells you to voetsek?"

"Then I write it up," says Anri. "Same day."

And there it is. That is the whole architecture of her: she will give a man the room to be better and she will not give him one centimetre more than that. It is the most dangerous quality a human being can have in the vicinity of a man like me, and I want to laugh out loud in the stores, and instead I say, "I'll come with you," and she says, "No you won't, he loves you, he'll perform," which is both true and the most precise thing anyone has said about me in eleven years.

We count. Ninety minutes. She counts left-handed, twice, initials in green.

Near the end she says: "Did you see the Sunday paper thing? The Sculptor."

The shelf in front of me contains nineteen boxes of size 4-0 suture and I do not move my hand at all.

"I saw a bit of it."

"Somebody in the class said it's a vet."

"Somebody in our class says the moon landing was filmed in Namibia."

"Ja, no, but the article said it," she says. "That the closing was — what did it say. That it looked like animal work." She squares the clipboard. "It's a stupid thing to write. There's like three thousand vets in this province."

"Twelve hundred and six," I say, "and about four thousand students and technicians, and the whole thing is probably two women who had work done and a journalist who needed a Sunday."

"Ja," says Anri, and hangs the clipboard on its nail. Then, at the door, with her hand on the light switch, in exactly the tone she uses for a stock discrepancy of no consequence:

"He'd have to have a theatre, though."

The strip light ticks off. The corridor light comes in through the wire glass.

"Who?" I say.

"Whoever. If he's real. You can't do that in a flat — you'd need a sterilizer, a proper one, and air, and a table, and nobody's going to

hear you.” She is not looking at me; she is looking at the door and finding her keys, and it is the most casual sentence in the world, and it is the single most frightening thing that has ever been said in my presence. “That’s the part I don’t get. In Cape Town? Where does a person put a theatre where nobody knows?”

The corridor. The wire glass. Her keys.

“Family money,” I say, and I hear my own voice do exactly what it always does, which is arrive on time in the correct tone with the correct amount of amusement in it. “Some Constantia oke with a wine cellar and a trust fund.”

Anri snorts.

“Ja,” she says. “Probably.”

And we walk out through the atrium past the photographs of ministers with scissors, and she goes left to the res parking and I go right, and it is a cold clear evening with the mountain black behind the faculty and the first winter stars coming out over Papegaaiberg, and I stand next to my bakkie for perhaps a minute and a half without opening the door.

Because I have understood, standing there, three things in a sequence, and I would like to set them down in the order they arrived, since the order is the whole of my defence and the whole of my indictment:

One. She was not testing me. There was nothing in it. It was a woman thinking out loud on her way to her car about a newspaper story, and if I had said nothing she would have forgotten it by the robot at Merriman.

Two. She got there in nine seconds. A newspaper article, a fact about suture patterns, and one honest question — *where does a person put a theatre* — and Anri Fourie, who was not looking for me, who has never suspected me of anything, arrived in nine seconds at the only load-bearing weakness in eleven years of my life. Not by suspicion. By *competence*. Because she cannot walk past a soft joint without pressing it.

Three, and I write this one down carefully, because it is the sentence on which everything after it turns:

There is no version of the winter in which she does not eventually press this one.

I got into the bakkie and drove over the pass with the heater on and the valley black on both sides, and somewhere past the co-op I noticed that I was, for the first time in my adult life, entirely without a plan — and that underneath the absence of a plan, in the place where fear should have been, was something else, something warm and enormous and moving, like a tide coming in over a flat beach in the dark.

The chapel was cold when I got there. I switched on the light and stood in the circle of deleted darkness for a while, and then I did the thing I had been not doing since March, which was to open the ledger to the clean spread at the back — the one I ruled in February and have never written on — and to sit down on the stool with the pen in my hand.

Four hours. A winter list. A woman in the January of her own face.

And on the left-hand page, where I keep the things that are not measurements, under the entry that reads *A. F. — 11/14. Thirty-one hours. Left-handed. Counts twice*, I did not write anything at all.

I sat with it for a long time. That is all. Then I closed the ledger, and put out the light, and went up the steps, and the valley was doing what it does, and I remember thinking, with the door key cold in my hand and the whole night in front of me:

Not yet. Not her. There's still the winter's work.

I have gone back over that thought many times since. It has never once, in any reading, been a refusal.

It has always been a schedule.

Sixteen — Over the Mountain

The map went up on the wall of the interview room on a Monday in June because the interview room had a door that locked and nobody had booked it since March.

Nkosi did the pins. Loots did the string, which he had bought himself at a hardware in Parow, and which the two of them agreed made the whole thing look like something from a television programme, and which was nevertheless the only way either of them had ever managed to see a case in two dimensions.

Red pins: the venues. Fourteen of them now, all within four kilometres of the sea, from the Waterfront down through Green Point, Sea Point, Bantry Bay, Clifton, Camps Bay. White pins: the flats. Same corridor. Between them, a spread of string so tight it looked like one place.

“So he hunts in a shoebox,” said Nkosi.

“He hunts in a shoebox,” Loots agreed, “which nobody lives in.”

That was the whole of it, and it had taken him four months to see it, and when he did see it he had to sit down on the corner of the table because it was so simple.

Nine of the fourteen approaches had happened on a weeknight. Every single victim had been returned to her own flat between two and four in the morning. In no case — not one, in two and a half years — had anybody seen a man walking to a car in the shoebox afterwards, and there was no CCTV of anyone leaving on foot, and the Seaboard

at three in the morning is not a place where a man on foot goes unnoticed.

“He drives,” said Loots. “Fine. Everyone drives. But where does he drive *to*?”

He put his finger on the map, on the mountain, and drew it inland: over the Neck, or round through the city bowl, onto the N1 or the N2, past the airport, out.

“If he lived in the shoebox he’d be walking. If he lived in the southern suburbs he’d be twenty minutes away and he’d have been seen by now, because that’s a small world and everybody’s got a Ring camera. So he’s coming from far enough that nobody in Clifton has ever seen his face twice.” He tapped the wall to the right of the map, where there was no map, only paint. “And there’s nothing over here, Warrant. That’s the thing that’s been bothering me since March. We’ve got fourteen approach venues and not one single sighting of this man anywhere else in this city. Ever. He doesn’t shop. He doesn’t go to a gym. He’s got no restaurant. He’s a man with no *life* in Cape Town.”

“Because his life is somewhere else,” said Nkosi.

Loots went out to the car and came back with the second map, the one he had bought at the CNA on Voortrekker Road with his own money because Provincial had not approved the request: the Western Cape, 1:250 000, the whole Boland spread out east of the mountains.

He pinned it up next to the first one, and it looked, for a moment, absurdly large — as though a small tidy problem had been put beside an enormous vague one.

“Ninety minutes,” he said. “Camps Bay to Stellenbosch at three in the morning with no traffic. I did it on Saturday night. Twice. Once via the N2, once over Helshoogte from Franschhoek.”

Nkosi looked at him.

“You drove it twice. At three in the morning.”

“Three fifteen and four ten,” said Loots. “I wanted the light.”

The faculty list had come back in April: two hundred and six students, sixty-eight staff, plus the Onderstepoort alumni resident in the province, which took it to three thousand and eight names, which was — as Delport had pointed out, holding the printout at arm's length like a summons — not a suspect pool but a phone book.

So they cut it.

They cut it the way Loots had learned to cut things in the nineties, before the databases, which was to write down what must be true and then throw away everything that could not be.

He is trained but not in humans. Vet, vet student, vet nurse, technician, or a man who did three years and left.

He has hands like that. Which meant surgical, which meant not a small-animal practitioner who spays and vaccinates and refers everything else; it meant somebody who cuts weekly, in a theatre, at a level.

He was refused medicine. Loots would not let go of this. Nkosi pushed him on it twice — “that’s a hunch wearing a suit, Captain” — and he took the pushing and did not move. “It’s the *surgeon* thing,” he said. “It’s the way he said it to Louw. That’s a man carrying a receipt.”

He has a building. Not a flat. A place with power, water, drainage, privacy, and no neighbour close enough to notice a light at three in the morning, within about an hour’s drive of the pass.

He has ninety minutes of dark road twice a night and it doesn’t bother him. Which meant, Loots said, a man who liked driving; a man who had been driving those roads since he was seventeen; a man for whom the pass at four in the morning was not a risk but a *pleasure*.

That last one was not evidence and both of them knew it. Nkosi wrote it on the board anyway, in the corner, under a heading she made up on the spot and which survived into the eventual court file: WAT ONS DINK. What we think.

The pool came down to two hundred and forty. Then, when Nkosi cross-matched against the two faculties’ historical medical-school applications — which took a subpoena, three weeks, and a data-protection officer at Tygerberg who eventually gave in because Nkosi

phoned her at 7:30 every single morning for nine days — it came down to thirty-one.

Thirty-one people in the Western Cape who had applied to study medicine, been refused, and become veterinarians or veterinary students instead.

“That’s a docket,” said Loots, looking at the list. “That’s an actual docket.”

“That’s a list of people who are going to hate us,” said Nkosi. “Every one of them’s going to get a knock on the door about the worst thing that ever happened to them at eighteen.”

“Ja,” said Loots. “So we knock politely.”

Ilse phoned on the Thursday.

He was in the car park at Bellville with a boerie roll he wasn’t eating and the phone lit up on the dash with a photo from 2018, and he looked at it for two rings before he could make his hand move.

“Ilse.”

“Hi, Pa.”

Neither of them said anything for a moment. Somewhere behind her there was a corridor, and voices, and a door.

“You left a message,” she said.

“Ja. Sorry. It was late.”

“It’s fine.” A pause. “You sounded — you didn’t sound drunk.”

“I wasn’t,” said Loots, and then, because there was no version of this in which anything except the truth would survive: “I haven’t had a drink in nine days.”

Another pause, longer.

“Okay,” said Ilse, carefully, in the voice of a girl who has been given this particular parcel before and has learned to check the weight of it. “That’s good, Pa.”

“It’s nine days. I’m not — I know what nine days is worth.”

“Ja.”

“How’s the semester?”

“Hard.” A breath that was almost a laugh. “We started dissection. Everyone said I’d be fine because I’ve got a strong stomach and it turns out the stomach is not the problem, hey. It’s the hands. It’s — you’re standing there with a scalpel and this person, this actual person who was a person, and you have to just — start.”

Loots sat in the car park with the boerie roll going cold on the seat.

“Ja,” he said quietly. “That’s the job.”

“Is that what it’s like? For you?”

And here it was: the first real question his daughter had asked him in eighteen months, arriving sideways, the way the good ones do.

“No,” he said. “Mine’s worse and better. You get given the person after. I get given them —” he stopped. Started again. “Ilse, the thing I do is I sit with people on the worst day of their lives and I ask them questions. That’s the whole job. The bodies are the easy part. You’ll be alright with the bodies by August.”

“Everyone else’s dad says ‘just don’t think about it.’”

“Everyone else’s dad has never had to think about it.”

She laughed — properly, once — and it went into him like heat into cold hands.

They talked for nineteen minutes. She told him about a lecturer who read his slides out loud. He told her, in the flattened, sanded-down version he had used with her since she was small, that he was working on a case that mattered, that there was a woman on it with him who was better at the computer part than he’d ever be, and that he was going to be on the road a lot in the Boland.

“Stellenbosch?”

“Around there.”

“Are you allowed to tell me what it is?”

“No.”

“Is it bad?”

Loots looked out of the windscreen at the parkade wall.

“It’s a man who thinks he’s helping,” he said.

“That’s the worst kind,” said his nineteen-year-old daughter, and then, “Pa, I have to go, I’ve got a prac at two.”

“Go. Go, my kind.”

“Bye. Um.” A pause of about a second and a half. “Bel weer. Not at midnight.”

She rang off. Loots sat with the phone in his hand for a while, and then he ate the cold boerie roll in about ninety seconds, standing up outside the car, in the wind, because he had discovered that he was extremely hungry.

That night he moved the string.

He took the fourteen red pins off the shoebox map, and he took a single new pin, black, and he put it on the second map, in the mountains, east of the city — not on a town, on the pass itself, in the gap between Stellenbosch and Franschhoek where the road goes over the shoulder of the Simonsberg and down through the vineyards.

Nkosi found it there in the morning and stood looking at it with her coffee.

“There’s nothing there, Captain.”

“There’s everything there,” said Loots. “That’s the road he loves. That’s the part of the night he’d keep.”

“That’s not evidence.”

“No,” he agreed. “Put it under *wat ons dink*.”

She did. And underneath it, in her own handwriting, in English, she added the line that would be read out five months later in a review board hearing by a colonel who wanted to know at exactly what point this investigation had stopped being a joke:

He isn’t hiding in the city. He’s commuting to it.

PART IV — THE ARCHITECTURE

*“If an injury has to be done to a man it should be so severe that his vengeance need not be feared.” — Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince**

Seventeen — Load-Bearing Beauty

Nadia Prinsloo sells houses in Bantry Bay and has, at thirty-four, the finest orbital architecture I have measured in a living human being.

I mean that technically. The eye socket is the part of a face that survives us — it is what an archaeologist has left to look at, it is what the Ife bronzes get right and Rome mostly does not — and hers is superb: the spacing, the depth, the way the malar comes forward off the maxilla and turns the light. She has the bones of a woman who will be photographed at seventy. And she has spent the last decade being described, by every man who has ever met her, as *striking*, which is the word English keeps for women who are magnificent and unloved.

The problem is not her face. There is nothing in her face that any hand should touch.

The problem is that her face is on top of a body that runs, from the eleventh rib down, four degrees out of the proportion her own skeleton has already promised — the waist-to-hip that art has been drawing since the Willendorf figure, that Ife draws, that Benin draws, that every culture on this earth arrives at independently the way they all independently arrive at the octave. A hipbone that says one thing and a soft-tissue distribution that says another. It reads, in a room, as a woman who does not quite go together. Nobody knows why. Nobody ever knows why; that is the entire cruelty of the mechanism.

Four degrees. On a woman who will be photographed at seventy.

The winter list has three names on it, ruled in February, on the last unused spread of the ledger, and hers is the first because hers is the one I have been ready for longest and because the work is four hours and June has the longest nights of the year.

I want to say something about the four hours before I say anything else, because everything that has been written about that night since — and a great deal has been written, by people who were not there, in language that suggests the whole thing was a frenzy — misses the only fact that matters, which is that it was *slow*.

Four hours is a long time. It is a working morning. It is longer than most surgeons in this province spend on anything. And a four-hour case is not four times as difficult as a one-hour case; it is a different animal entirely, because at four hours the enemy stops being the technique and becomes physiology. Temperature. Fluid. Position. The patient's own body clock. In a hospital there are six people in the room and four of them exist purely to fight that fight, and I had nobody, and I had known that I would have nobody since the day I poured the floor, and so I had spent eleven months building a room that could hold a person safely for four hours with one man in it.

Two monitors. A warming system. Redundant everything. A protocol written out in my own hand and laminated and hung where I could read it from the stool — twenty-two steps, most of which are *check* — because a man alone does not get to rely on his memory at three in the morning in the fourth hour.

I was not reckless. I have been called many things since and reckless is the one that is factually incorrect. Reckless would have been doing this in the workshop I had in 2021. I built a theatre, and I trained for it, and I rehearsed it, and I was — this is a matter of anaesthetic record, my own record, in my own column hand, seized from my flat and read out in a courtroom by a man who could not pronounce the drugs — I was within the physiological parameters I had set myself for three hours and fifty minutes of the four hours.

Three hours and fifty.

She goes to sleep at 11:40 on a Tuesday night in the middle of winter with the rain coming down the valley in sheets, and the ordinary

miracle happens, as it has happened four hundred and some times: a person, mid-sentence, becomes weight.

I want to describe what is in that room and I find that the vocabulary available to me is all wrong. If I say *tenderness* you will hear a lie. If I say *love* you will close the book. But the imagined reader is the only company I have ever kept, so let me try it once, properly, and then never again:

There is a woman on a table, in a two-hundred-and-twenty-eight-year-old room, in a circle of light with the whole black of the hillside pressing round it, and there is no one else on this earth awake within four kilometres, and for four hours I will hold her life in my two hands with nobody watching either of us. Nobody. No colleague, no nurse, no examiner, no God — I looked for Him in that room for eleven years and He does not come down the steps. Only me, and her breathing, and the numbers, and the rain on the hill.

If you have never had that, you cannot judge it. If you have had it — if you are a surgeon, or a midwife, or a paramedic on a wet road at two in the morning with your hands inside a stranger — then you know exactly the thing I am describing and you know that it is the closest a human being gets to the sacred while remaining employed, and you know that it is *not about you*, that the moment it becomes about you it curdles, and you spend your career keeping it from curdling.

Mine curdled. Not that night. Years before, and I did not notice, because there was nobody there to notice with me.

That is my whole confession, and it is not about her hips.

The work went beautifully. I want that on the record too, since I was denied the opportunity to say it anywhere it would be received: the work was *beautiful*.

Structural work is not the little theatre of the mouth. It is architecture — planes, load, symmetry, a plan drawn on the body before anything begins, measured to the millimetre against the hipbone she was born with and not against any magazine. I had drawn it eleven times. I had modelled it. I have, in the ledger, a page of that woman's own skeletal proportions with a target derived from her own iliac crest, which is more consideration than she would receive from any practice in this

city, where the target is whatever the patient shows the doctor on a phone.

By 03:10 I had done the difficult side. By 03:40 the second. At 03:50 I was closing, in my own pattern, buried, invisible, the signature nobody was ever meant to read, and I remember — I remember this with a clarity I would rather not have — thinking that I was going to be finished ahead of the protocol, and that I would sit for a while with the coffee flask and look at what I had made.

At 03:52 the numbers moved.

I am not going to describe what happened, and this is not the usual refusal. This one is not for your protection or mine; it is for hers. Somewhere in this country there is a woman who has read every word written about that night and who does not need a paragraph, written by me, of what it looked like from the stool. She was there. She has the only account that matters, and she does not remember it, and that is the single mercy in the whole affair.

What I will say is this, and it is the part that is true and the part that damns me, and both at once:

I did everything right.

I recognised it inside eleven seconds. I ran the protocol. Twenty-two laminated steps, in order, out loud, alone. I did the things that a hospital does with six people, by myself, for fifty-one minutes, and I did them well; I have gone over it four hundred times and there is not one step out of sequence. Anyone who has ever run a code alone will tell you that fifty-one minutes is not a period of time, it is a country you live in.

At 04:20 she was breathing on her own.

At 04:43, in the fourth hour of the longest night of the year, with the rain still coming down the valley and my hands entirely steady, I understood what the numbers had been telling me for the last twenty minutes, which was that she was going to live, and that something in the left side of her face was not going to.

I did not panic and I want you to hear how ugly that sentence is.

I stabilised her. I kept her under observation until the light came up grey over the Simonsberg. And then I drove Nadia Prinsloo home to Bantry Bay in the rain — ninety minutes, at the speed limit, with the wipers going — and I carried her up, and I put her on her bed on her side, dressed and covered, and I put the water on the nightstand, and I put the two Panados beside it, parallel, and I stood in her kitchen for one minute in the dark listening to her breathe.

And then — because there is a version of me that is only ever going to be a very good clinician with nowhere legal to put it — I made one alteration to eleven years of practice. I did not lock the door behind me and post the key.

I left the door on the latch, and I phoned emergency services from a phone that has never existed before or since, and I said: *A woman at this address needs an ambulance. She is breathing. She is post-operative. Her airway is fine. The door is open. Go now.*

They were there in twenty-two minutes. I know because I waited on the road above and watched them go in, which was the single stupidest act of my adult life and I would do it again.

Here is what I felt, driving back over the mountain in the winter dawn, and I have had a long time to check it, and the answer has never changed.

Not remorse. I have told you: the socket is dead, the light does not come on. I have looked, on that specific morning and on many mornings since, for the thing that a human being is supposed to feel when he has taken a woman's face away from her, and what is there instead is a kind of enormous cold *noise*, like standing next to a machine.

Not fear, either. That came later, and it was small and manageable and mostly about my keys.

What I felt, going up the pass with the wipers on and the first light coming, was this — and I write it because if this document is anything it is an honest one:

The material was wrong.

Not the plan. Not the room, not the eleven months, not the twenty-two steps, not the four hundred procedures of preparation, not the doctrine, not the mathematics. The mathematics is not capable of being wrong; that is what mathematics *is*.

Her tissue did not behave the way the plan required. Somewhere in that woman's own particular body was a variation I had not measured, could not have measured, and would have measured if I had had — and this is the thought that arrived at the top of the pass, whole, with the sun coming up on it —

if I had had a proper theatre. A team. Imaging. A pre-operative workup. All the things that a man with a piece of paper is handed on the first day and does not thank anybody for.

I have thought since about how thin the wall is between that sentence and the sentence *I am sorry*.

They are not the same sentence. I know that. I have never been confused about the difference; I have simply never had access to the second one.

I got home at half past seven, and showered, and drove to campus, and assisted Prof Krige at nine on a mandibular fracture repair in a working sheepdog, and at the end of it he looked at my closing for a while without saying anything, and then he said, in Afrikaans, quietly, the way you'd say it to a man at a funeral:

“Jy's gebore hiervoor, seun.”

Born for this.

And for the first time in eleven years, standing at that table with my hands still wet, I could not tell whether it was a compliment or a diagnosis.

Eighteen — What Did Not Wake

The call came to Loots at 06:11 from a duty officer in Sea Point who had been told, twice, by a captain in Bellville, that anything with the words *surgical, doesn't remember or procedure* in it went to him first no matter the hour, and who had put the note on the wall above the desk phone where the night shift could see it.

“Captain, we’ve got a female, thirty-four, Bantry Bay. Ambulance took her in about an hour ago. Post-op, apparently. She didn’t call it in herself and there’s no doctor attached to it.”

Loots was already standing. “Which hospital.”

“Christiaan Barnard. Captain — the paramedics say there’s surgery on her. Big surgery. And she was in her own bed.”

He phoned Nkosi from the car and got her at 06:14 and she did not ask a single unnecessary question, and that was the moment, he would say later, that the partnership actually began.

They met at the hospital at 06:50. The registrar who came down to them was about thirty and had been up all night and had the specific flat face of a doctor who has decided in advance not to be interesting.

“I can’t give you her medical information without —”

“I know,” said Nkosi. “Doctor, we’re not asking for her file. We’re asking one thing, and you can say yes or no. Is there surgery on that woman’s body that she did not consent to?”

The registrar looked at them both for four full seconds.

“Come with me,” she said.

Nadia Prinsloo was in a bed on the fourth floor with the curtain half round and her mother sitting beside her, and she was awake, and she was — this was the detail that Loots would not be able to put down for the rest of the year — trying to be polite.

She had come out of the theatre-that-was-not-a-theatre with a functioning airway, a stable heart, an intact mind, and a left facial nerve that had died somewhere in the fourth hour, and what that means, in the language of a woman lying in a bed at seven in the morning, is that half of her face no longer answered.

The left side did not move. Not the eyebrow, not the eyelid, not the corner of the mouth. When she tried to smile at them — and she tried, because she was a woman who had sold houses for eleven years and smiling at strangers was reflex — the right side of her face lifted and the left side stayed exactly where it was, and the effect, which no one in that room would ever describe out loud in front of her, was of a beautiful woman with a mask half off.

She was also — and this was the second thing — missing forty hours.

“I know it’s Wednesday,” she said. “They keep telling me it’s Wednesday. But I’ve got Monday, and then I’ve got the ambulance. And in between there’s —” the right side of her face did something complicated “— there’s a bit where I’m in a car. And it’s raining. And it’s fine. That’s the mad part, Captain. In the car bit I’m not scared. I’m being looked after.”

Loots sat down in the plastic chair so that his eyes were below hers, which was a thing he did without thinking about it any more.

“Mevrou Prinsloo,” he said. “I’m going to tell you three things and then I’m going to ask you nothing at all today. One: somebody did this to you. You did not do it and you did not agree to it and you did not forget agreeing to it. Two: you are the ninth woman I’ve sat with this year. You are not mad and you are not alone. Three —”

He stopped. Her mother, a woman of about sixty in a golf shirt who had driven from Somerset West at five in the morning, had put her

hand over her mouth.

“Three,” said Loots. “I’m going to find him.”

“Do you promise?” said Nadia Prinsloo.

Every single course he had ever been on, every legal advisory, every commander he had ever had, every instinct built over twenty-six years, said: do not answer that.

“Ja,” said Loots. “I promise.”

The corridor. The lift that took a long time. The parking garage on the third level with its low ceiling and its yellow paint.

Nkosi got in the passenger side and Loots got in and did not start the car, and then he got out again, and stood, and put both hands flat on the roof, and stayed there.

She let him have about a minute.

Then he hit the roof of the car once, with the flat of his hand — not a punch, an open hand, but hard, and the sound went across the whole level and came back off the concrete, and a woman getting into a Polo four bays down looked up and then looked away very quickly.

Nkosi got out on her side and stood with her arms folded, watching him over the roof.

“Captain.”

“I’m fine.”

“I didn’t ask.”

He was breathing the way men breathe at the top of a hill. His hand was flat on the metal and he was looking at it.

A hundred and ninety seconds, he thought. That’s how long you’re reasonable for.

“Warrant,” he said. “In April you wrote in your note that this was coming.”

“I did.”

"You wrote it and I put it in the file and I thought —" He stopped and looked at the concrete ceiling for a moment. "I thought I was being clever. I thought I was covering us."

"Ja," said Nkosi. "I know."

"It's June, and there's a woman on the fourth floor who thanked me. She said thank you, Warrant. To me. And there was nothing — Steenkamp gave me three of six things in April, and one of the three he didn't give me was the public appeal, and if that appeal had gone out in April with the water and the two tablets in it —"

"Then maybe forty women phone in and one of them is her and maybe none of them are," said Nkosi. "You don't get to know that. Nobody gets to know that."

"That's a very tidy thing to say."

"It's a true thing to say, and you can be angry at me for it later." She came round the car, and she stood in front of him, and she was eight inches shorter and it made no difference at all. "Captain. Look at me. I've read your file, I told you that. So I know exactly what this looks like from where I'm standing, and I'm going to say it once."

"Warrant —"

"Once." She held his eye. "Whatever it is you're feeling right now — that thing in your chest that's telling you it would be *right*, that's telling you the system is too slow and you're the only one who actually sees it and therefore your hands are the correction —"

Loots went very still.

"— that is the exact feeling that man had," said Nkosi, "in a cellar, on Tuesday night, with his hands on that woman's face."

The garage hummed. Somewhere below them a boom gate went up.

"You said I'd find him charming," said Loots at last, hoarsely.

"I said you'd find him *understandable*," said Nkosi. "That's worse, and it's the actual danger, and it's been sitting in the car with us since May."

He took his hand off the roof of the car.

"Get in," he said. "Please."

They did not go back to Bellville. They drove to the docks, which was Loots's place, and they sat in the car looking at the container cranes for a while, and at 08:40 he took out his phone and dialled, and Nkosi listened to one half of the strangest conversation she had heard in eleven years of policing.

"Kolonel. It's Loots... Ja. Ja, she's alive. Facial nerve. Permanent, they think... No, listen to me, please, before you say anything. I want to be taken off this docket."

Nkosi turned in her seat.

"Because I'm not the right man for the next part," said Loots, into the phone. "I can build it. I've built it. But there's going to be a day in about eight weeks when we put him in a room and someone has to sit across the table from him for six hours, and it can't be me... No. No, I'm not resigning, Kolonel, I'm *telling* you something. Put Nkosi in the chair. I'll be behind the glass... Because I'll like him," said Loots.

There was a long silence on the line.

"Because I'll sit down across from that man," he said, "and inside ten minutes he'll say a sentence I've said, and I'll know exactly what he means, and he'll see that I know, and after that he owns the room." He listened. "Ja. Ja, that's what I'm saying... No, Kolonel, it's not the drinking. I haven't had a drink in nineteen days. It's the other thing."

He listened for a long time.

"Dankie," he said. "Ja. I'll have the six-pager to you tonight."

He put the phone down on his knee.

"She said no," said Nkosi.

"She said no," Loots agreed. "She said the case is mine until it's finished and if I'm right about the interview we'll deal with the interview when we get to it."

"Then why did you phone her?"

Loots looked out at the cranes.

"So it's written down somewhere," he said, "that I knew."

The nineteenth of June: the day the docket stopped being a joke.

By four that afternoon the taskforce had a real room, twelve people, and a case number that ran under a heading with the word GBH in it, because a facial nerve is grievous bodily harm and grievous bodily harm is a language every station commander in the province speaks fluently. The public appeal Steenkamp had refused in April went out on the Thursday evening news, in Loots's words, with the water and the two paracetamol in it, and by Sunday night the dedicated number had taken four hundred and fourteen calls, of which fourteen were real, and one of which was a woman in Green Point who had been telling people about her nose since 2024.

And on the Friday, in the interview room with the two maps and the string, Nkosi took a black marker and wrote across the top of the second map, above the pin in the pass, the sentence that ran the rest of the winter:

He phoned the ambulance.

"That's the whole man," she said. "Right there. He broke her and then he made sure she lived. Captain — he is not going to stop, and he is not going to run, because in his own head he did not do anything wrong on Tuesday night. He had a bad outcome."

Loots stood looking at the map.

"Ja," he said. "And what does a surgeon do after a bad outcome?"

Nkosi capped the marker.

"He books the next case," she said.

Nineteen — The Material Was Wrong

For nine days after Nadia Prinsloo I did not go down the cellar steps.

I have read a great deal about what men like me are supposed to do in the aftermath of what the literature calls a disorganised event, and it is all wrong, or at least it is all written by people who have only ever interviewed the ones who were caught early. They speak of a cooling-off period, as if there were heat. They speak of the offender revisiting the scene. There was no heat and there was nothing to revisit; the scene was a room I had built and it was still there and it was still clean.

What there was, for nine days, was *work*, of the kind nobody outside a professional discipline understands.

I wrote it up.

Forty-one pages, in the ledger and out of it, on loose sheets I burned afterwards in the drum behind the werf: the anaesthetic record minute by minute, the fluid balance, the timeline, the twenty-two steps against the clock, the point at 03:52 and everything before it. Morbidity and mortality, single author, single attendee. Every hospital in the world does this and calls it a meeting and eats sandwiches at it, and what they do in that meeting is what I did alone for nine days, which is to ask, over and over, at every branch point: *what would I do differently*.

And the answer, when I had done it honestly — and I did do it honestly; I have never had any use for lying to myself, it is the one vice I have never had the taste for — the answer came out the same every time.

Nothing.

Not one step. Not the plan, not the anaesthesia, not the fifty-one minutes. Given that room, that patient, that night, I would do all of it again identically, and it would go the same way, because the failure was not in the sequence.

The failure was in the material.

I need to say something about that phrase, since it has been used against me by people who think it reveals contempt. It does not reveal contempt. It is what every surgeon says, in the tearoom, at eleven at night, when a case has gone wrong and they are frightened: *she was a difficult patient; the tissue was poor; there was a variant*. The whole of surgical culture is built on the distinction between an error and an outcome, because if you do not build it you cannot go back into the theatre in the morning, and someone has to go back into the theatre in the morning.

Nadia Prinsloo's tissue did not do what tissue does. There was something there — a variation in her own particular anatomy, running where it should not run, thinner than it should have been, or held where it should have been loose — and it was invisible to my hands and would have been invisible to any hands, and would have been *visible*, plainly, in colour, on a screen, to a man with an imaging suite and a pre-operative workup and a radiologist to argue with over a light box.

I did not have those things. I have never had those things. The reason I have never had those things is written on a piece of paper in a drawer in my flat, eleven years old, the yellow of old teeth, and it regrets, and it is unable.

So there is the sum, and I did it on the ninth day, sitting on the floor of the cellar with my back against the cold of the wall:

The doctrine is not wrong. The mathematics is not capable of being wrong. The plan was not wrong. The hands were not wrong.

The *conditions* were wrong. And they have been wrong for eleven years, and I have been producing exceptional results in them anyway, and I let that anomaly persuade me that the conditions did not matter, and a woman is paying for that arithmetic error with the left side of her face.

That is as close to guilt as this document is going to get. I offer it in the only tense I own: something was insufficient, and it was not my judgement, and it was not my hands, and I am the man who had to work in it.

Now. The other thing.

She is alive because I made her alive, and the ambulance is a fact I do not defend and will not be talked out of. But an ambulance is a phone call, and a phone call is a recording, and a recording is a voice, and there is a woman in Bantry Bay with an incision she did not order and forty hours she cannot account for, and by the Thursday of that week a policeman was on the evening news saying the words *a glass of water and two paracetamol tablets* in a tone I did not care for at all.

I watched it four times.

He is not a stupid man. That much was obvious at once — he was standing in a corridor at Provincial reading from a card, and the card had been written by someone else, and about a third of the way through he stopped reading it and looked at the camera and said a sentence that was not on any card: *We are not looking for a monster. We are looking for someone's clever, charming friend.*

I sat in the flat in Stellenbosch on a Thursday evening and looked at a man on television who had, in one sentence, described the operational core of eleven years of my life more accurately than any human being had ever described any part of me.

I would like to record that my first reaction was not fear.

My first reaction — and I have examined this, and it does not change however long I look at it — was *relief*. The relief of a man playing chess alone in an empty building who hears, at last, a chair pull out on the other side of the board.

They will get to the faculty. That is not a fear, it is a schedule. There are three roads in: the suture, which leads to a textbook, which leads to two schools; the wine bars, which lead to a face on a camera; and the drugs, which lead to a stores ledger. The first is already walking,

and it moves at the speed of subpoenas, which is to say ten weeks, perhaps eight. I know exactly what it will find when it arrives, because I have audited that building myself: it will find two hundred and six students and a workbook with my name on it that is the cleanest document in the province.

Eight weeks. Possibly ten. It is enough.

Enough for what, though? That is the question I sat with, and it is the question that produced the only decision in this account that I still cannot entirely look at straight.

Because here is what nine days of honest morbidity review actually established, underneath the fluid balances and the timings:

I have been building toward one piece of work my whole life. Not four hundred procedures — those were apprenticeship, I have said so, and I meant it. Not Demi Louw's mouth, which was a proof of concept, and not Nadia Prinsloo, which was a proof of the *conditions*. One piece. A single, complete, whole-face and whole-body work, planned over months instead of weeks, on a subject whose own architecture is close enough to the ratio that the entire distance can be closed — not corrected toward the peak, *landed on it*. The thing I have been describing since the first page of this document and have never once written down as a plan.

And the police are eight weeks out. And the room is finished and validated and will never be finished again.

So the winter list came out of the ledger, and I looked at the three names on it, ruled in February, and I did the thing I have done my whole life, which is the sum.

And the sum came out wrong.

I have gone over what happened next many times and I will set it down as plainly as I can, without the architecture I would normally build around it, because the architecture is what makes people say *he was rationalising* and this once I would like to be believed.

None of the three women on that list would land on it. Not one. I measured them all in February and they were the best available and *the best available is not the thing*. Each of them was a four-hour

case with a two-per-cent margin and a result that would have been extraordinary and would not have been *it*.

There is exactly one face I have ever measured in my life that would.

I have known it since March. I have known it, if I am honest — and I am being honest, this is the only place I am — since a Thursday in February in a stores room, with a clipboard and thirty-one hours of her own time and nine of my fourteen rows found, when I felt a thing I identified at the time as delight and wrote four words on the left-hand page of the ledger where I keep what is not a measurement.

The only one who might.

I told myself that sentence meant: the only one who might catch me.

It also meant the other thing. It meant it the day I wrote it. I have the ledger in front of me and the handwriting is completely steady.

Anri Fourie's face is, and I have now measured it nine times from photographs taken at the count and at the outreach clinics and at Krige's birthday in the marquee — one one-hundredth off the peak at three of the seven ratios and inside two millimetres at the rest. She is closer, untouched, at twenty-six, in fleeces, with her hair cut by her mother in Sutherland, than any woman I have ever seen or measured or corrected. She does not know it. Nobody has ever told her. She has spent her entire life being the sensible one, the competent one, the one who counts twice, in a world that has never once looked at her and gone quiet, because she is exactly two millimetres and a decade of never being asked away from a face that would stop a room.

And there she is. In the same building. Every Thursday. Holding the one thread that unravels me.

So let us be exact about the sum, since exactness is all I have left.

The doctrine says: the template must never be altered, and my work is performed on my own people. She is my own people. It permits her.

The clinical assessment says: she is the only subject on this earth on whom the complete work is possible.

And the operational assessment — the cold one, the one that a policeman on television would write in a notebook in Afrikaans and underline once — says that Anri Fourie is the single greatest threat to my continued existence, and that she asked me, in a corridor, in May, in a completely idle voice, where a person would put a theatre.

Three answers. Three different questions. One name.

I sat with that for four days. I want that noted too. Four days, in which I did not go to the cellar and did not sleep much, and on the fourth night I went and stood in the stores at midnight with the lights off, alone, with my hand flat on the shelf where she hangs her clipboard, and I said out loud, in the dark, to an empty room, the only prayer I have ever said in my life:

“Give me another one.”

Another face. Anywhere. One that lands on it, in a woman I do not know, in a city of four million people, in eight weeks.

Nothing. Of course nothing. The room was cold and smelled of disinfectant and there was nobody in it, as there has never been anybody in it, and after a while I switched the light on because standing in the dark is theatre, and I looked at the shelves, and I went home.

And on the Sunday I opened the ledger to that last unused spread — the one I ruled in February and have never written on — and at the top of the left-hand page, in the column hand I have used since I was twenty, I wrote a name and a set of measurements, and under the measurements I wrote the date I intended, which was the last Saturday in July, and under that the two words I have used to head a plan since I was a student:

Enkel geval.

Single case.

Then I sat back on the stool in the chapel with the light off, in that two-century cold, and told myself the sentence I have told myself at every gate I have ever walked through — that this was the culmination, that it was owed to me, that I was being permitted at last to do the one thing I was built for.

I have had a long time to think about that sentence since.

Here is what it actually was, stripped of the mathematics and the museums and the Florentine and eleven years of immaculate work:

A man with a locked room and a clock running down, deciding to cut the only person alive who had ever held him to a promise, and calling it a masterpiece.

Twenty — Warrant Mathematics

The thing that broke it was a key, and Loots had walked past it for four months.

He found it at 21:40 on a Tuesday in July, alone in the interview room with the two maps, going back through the Theron statement for the eleventh time because that was what he did when a case stopped moving — went back to the first witness and read her like a new one.

The key. The spare. It's under the mat, which I know is stupid. It was sideways. Wrong edge.

He sat with that for a long moment.

Then he phoned Margaux Theron at twenty to ten at night, which he apologised for twice, and asked her one question: after that morning in April when she had stood on the landing holding it and wondering — had she ever used that key again?

“No,” she said. “I moved it. I put it in the bowl by the door and I bought a proper lockbox thing, the one with the code.”

“Mevrou Theron,” said Loots, very carefully, “where is it now?”

“In the bowl.”

“In the bowl. Since April.”

“Since April.”

Loots closed his eyes.

“Don’t touch it,” he said. “Please. Don’t touch it, don’t move the bowl, don’t clean, I’m going to send somebody in the morning and I need you to not be helpful, do you understand? I need you to be lazy.”

Margaux Theron laughed — the first time she had laughed in his presence in four months.

“Captain,” she said, “I’ve been waiting since April for somebody to want something from me.”

The Local Criminal Record Centre lifted four usable prints off it: three of hers, and one partial off the bow of the key, in a position consistent with a key being held between finger and thumb and pushed through a gap under a door.

It went to AFIS on the Thursday. It came back on the Friday: no match.

Nkosi found him at the desk with the negative result in his hand and, she said later, thought for a second that he was going to put his fist through something. Instead he laughed — a short, astonished, entirely delighted bark — and said:

“Of *course* he’s not on the system.”

“Captain?”

“He’s never been arrested. Never been fingerprinted. He’s not a security guard, he’s not a firearms licence holder, he’s not a teacher, he’s never worked for the state.” Loots was already up, pulling his jacket off the chair. “Warrant, that print is worth more than a match. That print is a *comparison*. The day we’ve got a man, we’ve got him — but until then it tells us the one thing I’ve been guessing at for four months. He has never once been in the system. Not for anything. Not a drunk-driving, not a bar fight, not a domestic. Thirty years old and completely clean.”

“That’s most people, Captain.”

“That’s not most people who do this,” said Loots.

Then the Chenin.

It came from the second-least glamorous piece of police work in the province, which was Constable Ncube and two students on a learner-ship going through fourteen bars' worth of card-machine settlement records for fourteen specific nights across two and a half years — and finding nothing, because he paid cash, always, two-hundred-rand notes folded once.

What they found instead was the *order*.

Bar staff turn over on the Seaboard every six months, but stock systems remember everything. And on nine of the fourteen nights, in five different establishments, the same wine had been rung up on a table where a victim had been sitting: a 2019 Chenin from a small producer on the Pniel side of the Simonsberg, listed by three of those bars and, at two of them, not on the printed list at all — a bin-end, available if you knew to ask.

"He's not ordering a wine he likes," said Nkosi, standing at the white-board. "He's ordering a wine from home."

"Ja," said Loots.

"That's a farm nine kilometres from your black pin."

"Ja," said Loots.

They went out to the estate on a grey Wednesday and spoke to a marketing manager who was thrilled to be helping the police and who confirmed, in about four minutes, that the 2019 had been a tiny parcel, mostly cellar-door and a handful of restaurant accounts, and that anybody buying it in a Sea Point bar was either a wine person or somebody with a connection to the valley.

Then, in the car park, on the way back to the car, Nkosi stopped in front of a framed map on the wall of the tasting room — the estates of the valley, hand-drawn, decorative, the kind of thing that hangs in every cellar door in the Boland — and said, "Captain."

There were about forty properties on it. She was pointing at one on the Pniel road, small, marked with a name that meant nothing to either of them.

"What?"

“Nothing,” she said slowly. “It’s just — how many of these have a cellar that isn’t used any more?”

The marketing manager, who had followed them out, said cheerfully: “Ag, most of them, hey. Half the old ones can’t get certification. The families lease the vines out and the cellar just sits there.”

The faculty came in on the Monday, eight weeks after the subpoena, in four boxes.

Two hundred and six students. Sixty-eight staff. And the cross-match Nkosi had been running since April — everyone in that building who had applied to medicine and been refused — came back with a number Loots had not expected.

Fourteen.

“Fourteen out of two hundred and six?” said Delport, when he took it to her. “That’s not a coincidence, that’s an intake policy.”

“It’s the whole faculty, Kolonel,” said Loots. “It’s a new school. Half of them are silver medallists.”

They worked the fourteen for nine days, quietly, without knocking on any doors — because Loots had said in the taskforce meeting, twice, that the first knock they got wrong was the last knock they’d ever get. Enrolment records, timetables, address histories, vehicle registrations, the outreach roster, and, because Nkosi thought of it, the faculty’s own internal committee minutes, which nobody had asked for and which came in a single PDF of nine hundred pages.

She found it at 02:00 on a Thursday morning at her kitchen table.

She phoned him at 02:04.

“Captain. The stores.”

“Warrant, it’s two —”

“The drug stores at the faculty. The month-end reconciliation.” She was reading aloud, and he could hear the paper. “May fourteen. Audit committee. ‘The committee accepted the joint submission of Ms A. Fourie and Mr C. Vermeulen, final-year students, recommending that the wastage allowance be reduced from 2.1% to 0.6% and that all

variance be itemised at point of use. The committee commends this exemplary student initiative.’ ”

Loots sat up in the dark of the duplex.

“Say the name again.”

“Which one?”

“The second one.”

“Vermeulen. C. Vermeulen.” A pause, and the sound of a laptop being turned. “Captain, he’s one of the fourteen. Christiaan Vermeulen. Applied to medicine at Stellenbosch in the 2015 cycle. Refused. Enrolled veterinary science the following year at the new faculty. Fourth in his class.”

Loots was standing now, in the dark, in a room in Parow.

“He tightened his own stores,” he said.

“He tightened his own stores,” said Nkosi. “He wrote the submission that closed the gap he was using. That’s — Captain, that’s not a man covering his tracks, that’s —”

“That’s a man who’s got another way in,” said Loots. “And who wanted the tightest system in the country with his name on the committee minute.” He was pulling on trousers with the phone against his shoulder. “Where does he live?”

“Flat in Stellenbosch. Braak side.” Keys clicking. “And Captain — vehicle. There’s a bakkie registered to him, and there’s a second entry on the address history from three years ago that isn’t the flat. It’s a farm. Pniel road.”

The line went quiet.

“Say it,” said Loots.

“Vermeulen isn’t the registered owner,” said Nkosi. “The property’s in the name of a Frederik Louw Basson. Seventy-eight. Address in Hermanus.”

“The uncle.”

“Somebody’s uncle.”

Loots stood in the dark with his heart going like a man of half his age.

“Warrant,” he said. “Don’t come to Bellville. Meet me at Provincial at six, and bring everything, and don’t put any of it in an email tonight.”

They got the warrants on the Friday afternoon of the twenty-fourth of July, from a magistrate in Cape Town who read the eleven-page profile from the first line to the last while three police officers sat in front of her in silence, and who then took off her glasses and asked one question:

“Captain, this is a very good document. Why is there nothing in it about what he is doing right now?”

Loots had been waiting eight months for somebody to ask him that.

“Because he’s escalating, Your Worship, and because he had a bad outcome five weeks ago, and a man like this doesn’t stop after a bad outcome. He reviews it.” He kept his hands still on his knees. “He’ll have worked out what went wrong. And he’ll have decided the problem wasn’t him. So he’s not lying low. He’s planning something bigger, and he’s planning it now, and the only reason I can’t tell you when is that I don’t know what he thinks he’s short of.”

The magistrate signed three warrants: the flat on the Braak side, the vehicle, and the farm on the Pniel road.

They set the execution for 05:00 on Saturday the twenty-fifth, because that is when you do it — the last hour of the dark, when a man is at home and asleep and slow.

Outside on the pavement in Caledon Square, Nkosi looked at her copy of the warrant and said, “You alright?”

“No,” said Loots.

“Ja,” she said. “Me neither.”

Above them, over the mountain, the north-wester was coming in off the Atlantic the way it does in July, and the first fat drops were hitting the pavement, and by nightfall the whole peninsula would be under it.

Loots looked at the sky and thought, with a coldness that surprised him:

It's a Saturday night in the middle of winter. Longest dark of the year, near enough.

He's not going to be asleep. He's going to be working.

PART V — THE MASTERPIECE

*“Fortune is the arbiter of half our actions, but she leaves
the other half to us.” — Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince**

Twenty-One — The Glass She Never Drinks

The plan was ten weeks old and it was a good plan and it had one flaw in it, which is that it had been designed by a man who had never once, in four hundred procedures, had to think about how to get a woman to drink something.

They drink. That is the entire premise on which my adult life has been constructed. You sit in a room where drinking is the point, with a woman who came there to drink, and the wine arrives because the wine always arrives, and the only skill involved is the timing and the hands, and I have hands.

Anri Fourie has not had a drink in her life.

I knew this in February. I have known it since second year. It is on the left-hand page of the ledger in my own writing. And still, for ten weeks, some part of me had been running the old machinery underneath the new plan, the way you keep walking to where a wall used to be, and it was not until the Tuesday before the last Saturday in July — three days out, with the room prepared and the ledger ruled and the whole architecture of it standing there finished — that I sat down with a blank sheet and made myself write, at the top, the actual problem:

She does not drink. She does not take anything. She lives with two other students. She drives her own car. She is never in a bar. And she counts everything twice.

Four hundred procedures, and I had never had to solve this before, because I had never before wanted a woman who could not be

reached by the ordinary road.

I want to record what I did with that page, because it is the single most revealing document of my life and it was in my flat on Saturday morning and it is now, I am told, an exhibit.

I did not tear it up. I did not reconsider. I did not, at any point in those three days, entertain the thought that a plan requiring me to invent a new method from nothing, in seventy-two hours, on the one person in the province who could not be approached by any of my established routes, might be a plan that the universe was declining to permit.

I solved it. That is what I am. I sat down and I solved it, and the solving took two hours, and it was elegant, and it was the worst work I have ever done.

Here is the shape of it, and I give you the shape only, because I have kept faith with the imagined reader on this point for the whole of this document and I am not going to break faith on the last night: the answer was not a glass. The answer was the fact that Anri Fourie would, at any hour of any day, in any weather, get into her car and drive to an animal that needed her.

That is all. That is the entire mechanism. There was no cleverness in it and no charm and no seduction and no wine. There was a phone call at 21:40 on a Saturday night in the middle of a north-wester, from a colleague she trusted, about the outreach bakkie and a farm dog on the Pniel road with a torsion, and could she meet him there because Prof was in Hermanus and she was the only other person with a key to the drug box.

She said, "Give me twenty minutes."

She did not ask a single question. Why would she. She has driven four hundred kilometres in a night for a dog before. I have been in the bakkie with her when she did it.

I stood in the kitchen of that house with the rain coming across the werf in sheets and the phone in my hand and I understood, with complete clarity and no feeling whatsoever, that I had just used the best thing about a human being as the door into her.

Everything else I have done in eleven years, I can defend. I have defended it in these pages, at length, and I stand on it. That phone call I cannot defend and have not tried to.

She arrived at 22:20 in the little Polo with the bald tyre I had told her about twice, and parked in the werf, and got out into the rain in a fleece and a headtorch, and said, "Waar's hy?" — where is he — and I said, "In the cellar, out of the wind," and she said, "Slim" — smart — and went down the steps ahead of me.

Ahead of me. She went first, because she was the one with the drug box and there was an animal.

I will set down the next four minutes exactly because they are the only four minutes of my life I have gone back into every single day since.

The plan required her to be in the room. I had built the plan around the fact that she would go first, and she did. The plan required me to be behind her on the steps, and I was. And the plan required the improvisation — the thing I had solved in two hours on the Tuesday, which was pharmacological and fast and which I am not going to describe and which was, in its design, humane; I had chosen it precisely because it was the kindest of the available routes, and I would like some day to know whether that fact makes it better or worse, and I have never been able to work it out.

At the bottom of the steps she stopped in front of the steel door.

Not because she suspected anything. Because it was locked, and because she is a person who stops at a locked door and waits for the man with the key rather than rattling it.

And she said, over her shoulder, cheerfully, in the tone of a woman making conversation while somebody finds a key: "Ag, so this is the famous cellar."

And then she said: "Chris, what's that smell?"

Disinfectant. In a farm cellar, in the rain, at half past ten at night: the specific hospital smell of a room that has been cleaned to a standard no cellar has ever been cleaned to.

I had the key in the lock. I had my hand on it. And in the two seconds while the key turned I watched the back of Anri Fourie's head, and I watched her *not* turn around, and I understood that she had heard herself say it, and that the second count had begun — the one she does after the count you expect, the one that finds what is actually there.

The door opened. The light in that room comes on with a switch at shoulder height inside the doorframe and it does not come on gradually.

I have imagined many times what a person sees in that first instant. I had always assumed it would be the table.

It was not the table. She told them afterwards, and I have read it: it was the *floor*. The poured resin, coved at the walls, seamless, white — a floor with no join anywhere for anything to gather in, in a two-hundred-year-old wine cellar on a farm where the ceilings are held up with yellowwood.

She saw the floor and she knew everything.

And here is what Anri Fourie did, in the two-thirds of a second available to her, with no weapon, no phone signal in that hillside, no one within four kilometres, and a man behind her in the doorway:

She did not scream. She did not run into the room, which is what a running person does, because a running person goes forwards and the room was in front of her.

She went *sideways and down*, off the line of the door, and she put her whole weight into the drug box.

The drug box is a hard-shell case with a handle and a padlock and about eleven kilos of glass and steel in it and it is carried, always, by her left hand.

I have replayed it ten thousand times. I was reaching with my right. She swung eleven kilos, left-handed, from the floor, in the dark, at the arm that was coming — and it caught my forearm and the syringe and drove both back into the doorframe, and something in my wrist went, and the improvisation — the elegant, humane, two-hour improvisation that the entire plan stood on — went out of my hand and hit that beautiful seamless floor and rolled under the table.

Two seconds. That is all it was.

I have been asked since — in a room with a camera in the corner, by a woman with a file, in a voice of great patience — why I did not simply take her afterwards. I had size. I had the room. I had the door. She had a case with a broken lock and a bald tyre and nine kilometres of farm road in the rain.

The answer I gave was that my wrist was broken, which is true and is not the answer.

The answer is this, and it is the last true thing in this document:

I looked at her, in the doorway of the chapel, in the light of the room I had spent a year building for exactly this hour — and she was crouched on the floor with her arm up and her chin down and her eyes absolutely level, and she was not begging, and she was not screaming, and there was no going-away in her face, none, not a millimetre.

She was *counting*. I could see her doing it. Distance to the steps, distance to me, the weight in her left hand, the tyre, the road, the rain.

And I understood, in that doorway, with my wrist broken and the plan on the floor under the table, that I had spent my entire life measuring the wrong quantity — that I had built a mask and a mathematics and a doctrine and a room out of the belief that the distance between a person and perfection is two millimetres of tissue, and that here, one metre from me, on a cellar floor, was a face I had measured nine times and had never once seen, and it was doing the only thing I have ever found genuinely beautiful in a human being, which is working properly under load.

Nothing living lands on it exactly.

She did. Crouched on my floor, about to fight me with a drug box, at 22:24 on the twenty-fifth of July.

I stepped back out of the doorway.

That is all I did. I did not let her go, exactly; I have no appetite for that word and no right to it. I stepped back, one pace, off the line of the door, and I stood in the dark of the passage with my broken wrist against my chest, and Anri Fourie came up off that floor and past me

and up those steps in about four seconds, and I heard the cellar door, and I heard the Polo start on the second turn, and I heard the bald tyre spinning in the werf mud, twice, three times, catching, and then the engine going away up the farm road towards the Pniel turn-off in the rain.

I stood there for a long time.

Then I went into the chapel, and I picked the thing up off the floor and put it in the tray where it belonged, because I have never in my life left an instrument out. And I switched off the five-headed lamp that I rebuilt across four months with a soldering iron and a German service manual, and the darkness came back into that room after a year away, and I sat down on the stool in it.

She would be at the R310 in nine minutes. Signal, at the top of the hill, by the co-op — maybe fourteen.

I had, at the outside, an hour.

And what I did with that hour — I want this understood by whoever ends up reading this, because it is the only thing in eleven years that I did not plan, did not measure, did not audit, and cannot explain by any doctrine I have ever held —

was nothing.

I sat in the dark in the chapel and I waited for the policeman.

Twenty-Two —

North-Wester

The call came into the Stellenbosch station at 22:41 and it took nineteen minutes to reach Gideon Loots, and he would spend the rest of his career thinking about those nineteen minutes.

A young woman on a bad line from the top of the hill by the Pniel co-op, with rain and wind in the microphone, giving a farm name and an address and, in the first eleven seconds, before any officer had asked her a single question, the four things she had decided to say in the car:

“There’s a theatre in the cellar. It’s a fully equipped theatre. There’s a poured floor and a scrub sink and it smells like a hospital and he tried to inject me in the doorway and I hit him with the drug box and I think his arm’s broken. Christiaan Vermeulen. V-E-R-M-E-U-L-E-N. He’s a final-year vet student and he is the Sculptor and you need to send everybody.”

The constable who took it, twenty-three years old, fourteen months in the Service, said afterwards that he had never in his life heard anybody sound so calm and so angry at the same time.

He put it through as a possible assault, because that is what the system had a box for. It went up the line. At 22:52 somebody at the Stellenbosch station remembered the circular that had gone out to every station in the province in June, the one with the words *veterinary, procedure* and *Bellville — Capt. G. Loots (any hour)* on it, and at 23:00 Loots’s phone lit up in the duplex in Parow.

He had the warrant in his hand. It was in his jacket pocket, on the

back of the door, signed that afternoon, for an execution at 05:00.

He phoned Nkosi at 23:02 and she was already awake.

The north-wester had the whole peninsula by then — the kind of July storm that takes the tents off the Waterfront and puts water through roofs that have been sound for forty years — and the N1 out of the city was a river of red light and spray.

Nkosi drove, because Loots asked her to, which she noted and did not comment on.

He was on the phone the entire way: Stellenbosch station commander, Provincial, Delpont, the duty prosecutor, the TRT commander at Bellville who wanted to know why a tactical unit was being pulled at midnight for a docket with the word *cosmetic* anywhere in it and who stopped asking after about forty seconds. He asked for an ambulance to be staged at the Pniel turn-off and would not say why, and then, when the man pushed him, said: “Because I don’t know how many people are in that cellar.”

By Klapmuts the rain had gone from bad to biblical. Nkosi came off the R304 at 80 with the wipers doing nothing at all and said, “Captain. Talk to me about him.”

“Now?”

“Now, while there’s nothing else to do. Because in about twenty minutes it’s real, and I want you to have said it out loud in a car with a witness.”

Loots looked at the road for a while.

“He’s not going to run,” he said.

“You said that in June.”

“I’m saying it now, when it counts.” He turned the warrant over in his hands. “Warrant Officer, everything that man has ever done, he’s done because he thinks he’s the only person in the room who sees clearly. He’s never been arrested, never been challenged, never lost an argument. Tonight a twenty-six-year-old with a drug box beat him in two seconds in his own doorway.” He put the warrant in his inside pocket. “He’ll be there. He’ll be sitting somewhere clean with his

hands where we can see them and he will have thought about how to be arrested, and he'll be *good* at it, and the whole thing will feel civilised, and that's the moment you must not believe."

"And you?"

"What about me?"

Nkosi took the Simondium turn and the wind hit the car sideways and she corrected it without comment.

"Captain, in nine minutes you are going to be in a room with the man who did that to Nadia Prinsloo," she said. "You told Delport in June you didn't want to be. That was you being right about yourself. So I'm asking now, in the car, where there's a witness: are you going into that cellar?"

Loots was quiet for four seconds.

"No," he said.

"Say the rest."

"You go in with the team. I'll be outside on the werf, and I'll be on the radio, and you'll do the arrest and you'll do the caution and you'll put him in the van." He looked out at the black rain. "And if he says one word to me on that farm, you get between us. That's not a request from a captain, Nkosi, that's a —" He stopped. "Ja. It's a request."

"Noted," said Nkosi, "in the weekly note," and something in the car eased about a millimetre.

There is a detail from that night that came out four months later, in a review board hearing, and it is the reason a colonel who had come prepared to end Gideon Loots's career in the Service instead wrote the words *judgement demonstrably restored* in a paragraph nobody expected.

At 23:04, in the duplex in Parow, with the phone against his shoulder and the warrant in his hand and nine things to do, Captain Loots had opened his gun safe.

His service pistol was in it. His father's Ruger — a .357 that had come down from a farm near Riversdal and that had no business

being anywhere near a police operation and that he had, in eighteen months of very bad nights, taken out and put on the kitchen table more than once — was in it too.

He took the service pistol.

He locked the safe, and he checked it was locked, and then, and this is the part that went into the record, he drove nineteen minutes out of his way to Bellville, in the storm, with a tactical team already rolling, to leave the key to that safe with the duty officer at the charge desk and to sign it into the register in his own handwriting at 23:19.

Nkosi, who had been sitting in the car outside with the engine running, asked him what he'd been doing in there.

"Housekeeping," said Loots.

They came onto the farm at 23:44 from two directions, with the lights off on the last four hundred metres, and the werf when they came into it was a black square of water and mud with one small Polo parked crooked in the middle of it, driver's door still hanging open, dome light on, filling with rain.

That was the thing that got them all moving faster than any briefing had: the open door of that little car.

The house was dark. The cellar door was open at the top of the steps, and a light was on somewhere down there, low and yellow, not the white of a theatre — a work light, or a phone.

They went down the steps in the way they train for and there was nothing to fight.

The steel door was standing open.

The room behind it was white and cold and immaculate, and every officer who went into it that night described it afterwards in the same three words, in three separate statements, without conferring: *like a hospital*.

The five-headed lamp was off. The table was made up with a clean drape, squared. There was a laminated sheet hanging by a bulldog

clip at eye height beside the stool with twenty-two numbered steps on it. There was an autoclave with a validation log open beside it and a pen resting in the gutter of the page. There was a second aspirator, still boxed, unopened, on the shelf.

And on the floor, in the middle of a poured white resin floor with no join in it anywhere, sitting cross-legged with his back against the leg of the operating table, in the dark, was a young man with wet hair and a right forearm held against his chest at an angle that made two of the officers wince, doing absolutely nothing at all.

He did not move when the lights came on. He turned his head slightly, the way a man looks up from a book.

“Good evening,” said Christiaan Vermeulen. “There’s nobody else here. There’s nobody in the house and nobody in the outbuildings and there is nothing in this room that will hurt any of you. The drug fridge is behind you and it’s locked and the key is in my left trouser pocket and I’d rather one of you took it out than me, because my other arm is broken.”

Nkosi came in second. She did the caution. She did it word-perfect, in English and then in Afrikaans, and he listened to all of it with his head slightly tilted, and at the end he said, “Dankie, dis duidelik,” — thank you, that’s clear — and offered his left wrist first to make the cuffing simpler.

Somebody said, later, that it was the politest arrest they had ever been part of, and Nkosi said, “Ja. Write that down too.”

Loots stood in the werf in the rain.

He heard it all on the radio. He heard “in custody” at 23:51 and he heard the TRT commander clearing the house and he heard Nkosi’s voice, flat and controlled, calling for the LCRC and a photographer and a doctor for the suspect’s arm, and he stood in ten centimetres of water in his shoes with the rain going straight through his jacket and did not move.

They brought him up at four minutes past midnight.

Two officers, one at each arm, the wet steps, the yellow torchlight — and Loots was standing ten metres away by the vehicles with his

hands in his pockets, and the young man came up out of the ground into the storm and stopped.

Not to resist. He simply stopped, and looked around the werf at the vehicles and the lights and the people, and found the one man standing on his own who was not doing anything, and looked at him.

There was about four seconds of the two of them.

Even in the dark and the rain, Loots would say afterwards, he could see the assessment happening. The eyes went over him once — face, shoulders, hands, shoes — the way you'd read a page.

And then Christiaan Vermeulen smiled at him. A small, warm, entirely genuine smile, the smile of a man recognising a colleague at a conference, and drew breath to say something.

Nkosi stepped between them.

She did it without hurry, sideways, one pace, so that she was simply in the way, and she said, "Kom," and the officers moved him on to the van, and whatever the sentence was, it was never said, and Loots would wonder about it for the rest of his life and never once ask.

He stood there in the rain until the van had gone down the farm road.

Then he walked over to the little Polo with its door still hanging open and its dome light burning and its seat soaked through, and he leaned in, and switched off the light, and closed the door properly, so that the inside of Anri Fourie's car would not be any wetter than it had to be when somebody eventually brought it back to her.

Twenty-Three — Irrational

They put me in an interview room at Provincial with a camera in the corner and a table bolted to the floor, and across from me they put the one person in that building I could not use.

I had expected the policeman. I had prepared for the policeman — and I mean prepared in the technical sense: I had spent the hour in the cellar and the drive in the van and the seven hours in the cells at Stellenbosch running the conversation, and I had a version of it I was looking forward to in the way you look forward to a difficult examination that you know you will pass beautifully.

He never came. Not once, in nineteen hours of interviews across three days.

They gave me Warrant Officer Zintle Nkosi, who was thirty-six years old and wore a jacket that fitted properly and who did not want anything from me at all.

That is the whole of it, and it took me most of the first day to understand it. Everything I have — everything, the entire apparatus, eleven years of it — runs on wanting. The women wanted to be seen. Krige wanted a protégé. The faculty wanted an exemplary student. My father wanted to be forgiven and my mother wanted me to be a doctor and every person I have ever met has walked into the room carrying something they needed, and I have never had to do more than notice it and hold out my hand.

Nkosi came into that room with a file and a bottle of water and nothing else. She did not want my confession — she had a floor with no join in it, an autoclave log in my handwriting, a ledger with four hundred women's measurements in it, a letter from a medical faculty,

and a witness who had counted the whole thing in two seconds in a doorway. She did not need one word from me and she told me so, on the first morning, in the second minute.

“You can talk or not talk, Mr Vermeulen,” she said. “It doesn’t change what I’ve got. I’m here because the law says you get the chance to give your side, and because I think you’re going to want to, and I’d rather it was recorded than said to a psychiatrist in twenty years’ time.”

And then she waited, without any tension in her at all, and I found that I had nothing whatsoever to hold onto.

I talked for nineteen hours. Of course I did.

I told her about the mask and the ratio and the distribution and the two millimetres. I told her about Elmien Titus at the back of a church in Pniel and about the Ife heads and about eleven billion dollars a year of skin lightener. I built it for her the way I have built it in these pages, and I built it well, because it is the only cathedral I have and it is genuinely well made.

She let me finish. She let me finish everything, every time, which I now understand was itself a technique and one I would have used myself.

And then, on the afternoon of the second day, when I had put the entire doctrine on that table between us — the museums, the anthropometry, the whole of it — she closed her file and asked me four questions.

“Mr Vermeulen, what is Margaux Theron’s mother’s name?”

I said that I did not see the relevance.

“Demi Louw taught six classes a week above a Woolworths. What were they called?”

I said that I did not know.

“Bianca Steyn was frightened of the sun. Do you know why?”

I said that it was a fair-skinned woman’s ordinary —

“She had a brother,” said Nkosi. “He died of a melanoma when she was nineteen. She’s been going to a dermatologist every six months since she was twenty and terrified every single time, and you gave her four shades of pigment in her sleep and she told forty thousand people it was a supplement, and now she can’t look at her own arms.” She did not raise her voice at any point. “Fourth question. You’ve measured four hundred and eleven women. In eleven years, did you ever ask one of them what she wanted?”

I said — and I remember the exact shape of the sentence, because it was the last piece of architecture I ever built and it collapsed in my mouth — I said that asking was precisely the problem; that a woman asked will only ever request what the culture has told her to request; that the entire cosmetic industry is a machine for taking orders from people whose taste has been manufactured, and that the only honest position was to work toward the ratio rather than toward the order form.

“Ja,” said Nkosi. “So: no.”

“That’s not —”

“It’s a yes-or-no question and the answer is no.” She put her pen down. “Mr Vermeulen, I’ve listened to you for two days and I want to tell you what I’ve actually heard, and then we can carry on with the timeline. You’ve told me that white beauty standards are a colonial theft. That’s true. You’ve told me that African proportion is the human template and the museums prove it. Also, broadly, true — and it isn’t yours, and you didn’t discover it, and half the art historians in this country have been saying it for forty years without cutting anybody.”

“I’ve never touched a Black woman. Never. Not once.”

“I know,” she said. “You worship us instead. You’ve built a whole theology where we’re the standard and the sculpture and the template — and in eleven years of that, you never once had a Black woman in your life you had to have an actual conversation with. Not one friend. Not one colleague you asked about her weekend. You had Elmien Titus when you were eleven, and the day it cost something to know her, you stopped speaking to her, and instead of ever picking up a phone you built a *number* out of her face and measured other women against it for eighteen years.”

The room was very quiet. The camera in the corner made its small noise.

“That’s not reverence, Mr Vermeulen,” said Nkosi. “That’s the same thing the men who put those bronzes behind glass did. You take a person, you decide she’s perfect, you put her where she can’t answer back, and then you use her to justify what you do to somebody else’s body. It’s a compliment with a knife in it. And I have met about four hundred of you, and you are the only one who built a theatre.”

I have no answer to that. I have had a very long time and I have never once constructed one that survives being read the next morning.

They let my lawyer’s psychiatrist see me in September and she wrote fourteen pages, most of which I could have written for her, and one paragraph of which I have thought about every day since.

She wrote that in four hundred and eleven procedures I had never completed the thing I claimed to be doing.

That the escalation was not, as I had presented it, a ladder toward a masterpiece — that a ladder has a top and mine did not — but a *pursuit*, and that the object of a pursuit which cannot conclude is not the object at all. That every single time I closed a wound and the tap turned off in me thirty minutes later, I had been told the truth by my own body and had refused to hear it, because the alternative was unbearable.

The number, she wrote, was the confession. I had chosen, as the organising principle of my life, a quantity that is by definition unreachable — an irrational number, non-terminating, non-repeating, a decimal that runs forever without settling — and I had built a doctrine, a room, and eleven years of immaculate work on the promise of landing on it exactly.

You did not choose an unattainable standard by accident, she wrote. You chose it because a man who has landed has to stop, and you could not afford to stop, because the ache that arrives thirty minutes after the last knot is not the ache of imperfection. It is the ache of being alone in a room with yourself. And it was there when you were eleven years old, at the back of a church, and no amount of anyone else’s skin has ever once touched it.

I told her she was wrong. I made a good argument. She let me finish, the way they all let me finish.

Then she asked me the only question in eleven years that I have never been able to get out from under, which was:

What were you going to do on the Sunday?

Because there was a Sunday. Whatever I had planned for that Saturday night — however complete, however perfect, however exactly it landed on the number — the sun was going to come up on the twenty-sixth of July, and I was going to drive back over Helshoogte in the gold hour, and thirty minutes after the last knot the tap was going to turn off, exactly as it has turned off four hundred and eleven times.

And there is no fifth part of the plan. There has never been a fifth part. I have looked, and there is nothing behind it, and there never was.

One last thing, and then I am finished with this document, which was never for you.

They asked me in the third interview — Nkosi asked, in the flat voice she used for the timeline — why I stepped back out of the doorway.

I gave her three answers over two days. The wrist. The time. The tyre.

Here is the fourth one, which I did not give her, and which is the only one that is true.

When the light came on in that room, Anri Fourie went sideways and down and got her weight behind eleven kilograms of drug box, and her face while she did it was the most beautiful thing I have seen in my life — and I had measured that face nine times and written the numbers in a ledger and been *wrong about all of them*, because the numbers were of a face at rest, and what I saw in the doorway was a face at work: frightened and fast and completely unwilling, doing the arithmetic of its own survival at a speed no mask can measure.

Nothing living lands on it exactly. Everything living is *doing* something, all the time, and the doing is where the beauty is, and it cannot

be entered in a column and it cannot be improved and it certainly cannot be improved by putting the person to sleep first.

Eleven years. Four hundred and eleven women. A cellar with a floor that has no join in it.

And I only ever saw it once, for about two-thirds of a second, in the face of the one woman I could not put to sleep.

I have thought about writing to her. My lawyer advises against it, and my lawyer is right, and for once I am going to do the thing a man in my position should do, which is nothing.

She would not read it anyway. She would look at the envelope, and she would think about it properly, twice, the way she thinks about everything.

And then she would count it as what it is.

Twenty-Four — The Mirror, After

The ledger was the ninth item logged out of the flat on the Braak side and the only one that made the photographer stop working and stand still.

Loots read it that Sunday afternoon at Provincial with gloves on and Nkosi across the table, and it took them four hours, and neither of them said very much.

Four hundred and eleven entries. Each one a date, a set of measurements in a small even column hand that did not vary at all across eleven years, a procedure, a duration, and a two- or three-word outcome note. *Uitkoms: uitstekend*. Outcome: excellent. No names — never names, not once in four hundred and eleven entries, only initials and an age.

On the left-hand pages, occasionally, a line that was not a measurement. There were about forty of them across the eleven years. They read like a man talking to himself in an empty building.

She kept the photograph. He said born for this again today. The tap turns off at thirty min. Consistent. Investigate. A. F. — 11/14. Thirty-one hours. Left-handed. Counts twice. The only one who might.

And beneath the ledger, in the same drawer, flat as a pressed flower, a letter from the Faculty of Medicine and Health Sciences dated eleven years earlier, in which the university regretted, and was unable.

Loots looked at it for a long moment through the plastic of the evidence bag.

“One mark,” he said.

“You don’t know that,” said Nkosi.

“No,” he agreed. “But he does.” He put it down on the table between them, squared it with one gloved finger, and did not touch it again. “Warrant, I’m going to say a thing and you don’t have to answer it.”

“Ja.”

“If they’d given him the place,” said Loots, “he’d be a surgeon at Groote Schuur right now, and he’d be brilliant, and Nadia Prinsloo would have a face.”

Nkosi thought about it for a while.

“Or there’d be a consultant at Groote Schuur,” she said, “who’s brilliant, and who nobody can ever quite put a finger on, and it would be theatre staff instead of women in bars, and it would have taken thirty years to catch him instead of eleven months.” She snapped off a glove. “Captain, that letter is not the reason. It’s the excuse. He kept it in a drawer for eleven years because a man like that needs one thing in his life he can point at and say *that’s why*, and it can never be himself.”

The trial ran the following winter and lasted nine weeks.

Nadia Prinsloo gave evidence on the fourth day. She had had two operations by then — a nerve graft in the December, a static suspension in the March — and the left side of her face had recovered enough that a stranger meeting her would have said only that something about her was very still. She testified for two hours and forty minutes. She was asked, by a defence counsel who was doing his job and who apologised to her afterwards outside on the steps, whether she was aware that her surgical outcome, in purely aesthetic terms, had been described by two independent experts as excellent.

“Yes,” said Nadia Prinsloo. “And if he’d asked me, I’d have said no thank you, and I’d still be able to close my left eye when I sleep.”

Demi Louw came on the sixth day, and did not once put her hand in front of her mouth.

Margaux Theron came on the ninth.

Bianca Steyn refused to testify, then agreed, then refused, then came anyway on the eleventh day without telling anybody she was coming and sat in the corridor for four hours before she went in.

Anri Fourie testified for fifty minutes and answered every question in complete sentences, and when the defence put to her that her identification of the room's purpose had been an assumption made in a moment of panic, she said, "No. It was a floor with no join in it in a two-hundred-year-old cellar. You don't pour a floor like that unless you're going to have to wash it."

Priya Naidoo brought the blue textbook with the cow on the cover into court with all forty tabs still in it.

Vermeulen pleaded not guilty on the schedule and guilty on the facts — a distinction his counsel worked hard on and which nobody in that courtroom ever really understood except, possibly, Vermeulen. He was polite to everyone. He stood when he should. Two of the journalists covering it wrote pieces about how ordinary he seemed, and one of them used the word *charming* in a headline, and Loots read that piece standing up in a Woolworths and put it back on the rack.

The sentence was handed down in the September: an effective term long enough that the arithmetic of it did not matter, with a note in the judgment that the court had considered the absence of any prior conviction and had found it, in the circumstances, an aggravating rather than a mitigating fact.

Loots did not go to the sentencing.

He went, instead, on a Tuesday two weeks earlier, to the holding facility, and stood in the corridor outside the section for about ninety seconds, and did not go in.

He had told himself for fourteen months that he wanted to know what the sentence in the werf had been going to be. He had rehearsed the conversation the way he had once rehearsed interviews. And standing in a corridor that smelled of floor polish and other men's cigarettes, he found that the want was gone — not resolved, not conquered; simply gone, the way a fever goes, leaving a man tired and slightly amazed.

There is a thing about those sections that the public does not know. There are no glass mirrors anywhere. Glass breaks, and broken glass has uses, so what they put above the basins is a sheet of polished steel screwed to the wall: unbreakable, faintly warped, and honest in the way of all cheap reflective surfaces, which is to say not honest at all.

Loots stood in the corridor and thought about a young man who had spent his whole life measuring faces to the millimetre, brushing his teeth every morning for the rest of his sentence in front of a piece of steel that would give him back a face two millimetres wrong in every direction and never the same wrong twice.

He turned around and walked back out to the car park, and phoned his daughter, and got her voicemail, and left a message saying he'd be in the Tygerberg area on Thursday if she wanted a coffee.

She phoned back in four minutes.

They had the coffee. She told him about a lecturer she couldn't stand and a friend who was dropping out. He told her — because she asked directly, which she had learned to do that year — that it had been fourteen months and nineteen days, and that some weeks were fine and some weren't, and that Tuesdays were the worst and he had no idea why.

"Ma says you're back at Provincial," said Ilse.

"Ja. Group commander, violent crimes. From the first of November."

"Is that —" She frowned. "Is that the same job you had before? Before the —"

"Before the video," said Loots. "Ja. Same job. Same office, actually. It's got a new carpet."

Ilse turned her cup around on the table twice.

"How do you feel about that?" she asked, and Loots understood, with a small shock, that his daughter was going to be a very good doctor.

"Old," he said. "And like I'd better not drop it."

Margaux Theron came into the last of it almost by accident.

She had been on the witness list, and she had testified, and after that the machinery had let her go, which was what she had been waiting eighteen months for and which, when it happened, she found she did not know what to do with.

In the December — the summer after the trial, a Saturday, the south-easter working itself up over Table Mountain — she was in her flat in Camps Bay, in the bathroom, in the morning light, which is honest there in a way it is honest in very few places on this earth.

She had not looked at herself in the magnifying mirror since April of the previous year. She had, in fact, taken it down and put it in the cupboard under the basin, behind the spare towels, where it had sat through the winter of the storm and the trial and the sentencing.

That Saturday she got it out and put it back on the shelf.

She was thirty-three now. There was a line beside her mouth that had not been there two years ago, and a scattering of sun damage across her nose that Dr Naidoo — who was, absurdly, her actual dermatologist now, and who had cried in her rooms one afternoon in the winter and then made them both tea — had told her to keep an eye on. Her father had been dead for six years. Her mother, whose name was Sonja, phoned on Sundays.

She leaned in and looked at her left eyebrow.

Smooth. Perfect, in the technical sense: not a mark on it, not a pucker, not a seam. Eleven millimetres of nothing at all, where twenty-two years of her had been.

Margaux put her fingertip on the place, the way she had a thousand times since — the ordinary way now, not the little tap-and-press her ring finger used to do, that habit having finally, sometime in the spring, simply stopped.

She stood there for a while in the good light with the wind starting up outside.

Then she said, out loud, to the mirror, in the flat and slightly amused voice of a woman closing a matter that has taken up quite enough of her life:

“Ja, well. It’s my face.”

And she put the mirror back in the cupboard, and went to the beach.

About This Book

The Surgeon — complete first draft, Arjuna Badger Press workshop shelf.

Perfection is irrational.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor